

Hist 450 Winston Churchill: The Roaming Lion

Numbered Transcript

HIST 450 • Dr. Larry Arnn

Contents

Lecture 1. Beginnings of a Statesman

Lecture 2. Churchill on Governance

Lecture 3. Churchill on Warfare

Lecture 4. Churchill on Leadership

Lecture 5. Churchill on Politics

Lecture 6. Churchill on Civilization

Lecture 1: Beginnings of a Statesman

At a glance — Arnn traces Churchill's beginnings as a statesman.

- 1.1 Welcome to this online course about Winston Churchill as part of the curriculum of the Peterson Academy. My name is Larry Arnn. I work at Hillsdale College. I am here because, like almost everybody else, I am charmed by Jordan Peterson, and to some small extent, dominated by him. If you meet him, which I hope everybody gets a chance to do, you'll find out that he analyzes you. My particular way of dealing with him is to analyze him back. But I won't do that during this course because that might be too much.
- 1.2 So, Winston Churchill. Winston Churchill died in 1965, 60 years ago, round numbers. Why is he of any interest? I'll try to explain that. There's a reason in principle why he and everyone like him is of interest. I'm going to talk about that first. I fear that that might be boring because it involves a bunch of arguments about the nature of human beings. Maybe they won't be. I don't know. I don't find them so, anyway. And then I'll tell some stories about him that tell you what kind of guy he was, because he was a very remarkable human being.
- 1.3 You don't have to like him or approve of him or agree with him to think that. If you just know about him, you'll go, "Wow, look at that." So, what is that argument? It's an argument about what statesmen do. They do something that we all do. Most of the time, I'm going to make a classical argument to you. Apart from Churchill and some other things, I teach Aristotle at Hillsdale College, and that's the greatest dang thing there is. And so, Aristotle is good at explaining what's going on in us, what's going on in our souls. He's the classical Jordan Peterson. Our mental weather, you might say, is mostly made up of making choices.
- 1.4 Now, there's a higher thing than making choices, and that's figuring out something that's always true, things that never change. That's the highest kind of knowledge. But we don't use that all the time. And the reason is we're always busy figuring out what to do. Some of you in the audience here, I know you made a trip to come here. That's a pain. You chose it. There were disadvantages. You had to give up something to come here because you couldn't be doing whatever else you'd be doing at that time. You made a comparison about the good, about what the best thing is.
- 1.5 But the best thing is not enough to decide. You also had to make a choice about the obstacles. And there are many, right? Hard to get here. Is it worth it? What do I give up? What's going on when we make a choice? Choices are very significant for us. According to Aristotle, they're more important than actions informing our characters. Our character is something we make by making choices over and over and over again.
- 1.6 And if we make them badly and we're resolute about it and particularly talented, we can become Adolf Hitler. Not many people actually do that. But if we make them

resolutely and we're really good at it and we make them in the right way, we can become superior people, splendid people. And it's our choosing that makes that. Human freedom lies in that fact, according to Aristotle. Well, we need to be good at that. And Aristotle says in Book 6, Chapter 2 of the Nicomachean Ethics, one the greatest books ever written, he says that if you want to learn how to do that, study people who have the reputation for doing it well.

- 1.7** And then he names an example—Pericles, a statesman. And he names that example because Pericles is like all statesmen. They make big choices that involve all of us in public. And they're just like us. They don't know the future any better than we do, and they somehow seem to be gifted at that. Studying examples is a great way to get better at that. Experience is the really best way to get good at that. Turns out, experience is costly. Takes a lot of time, and also you make a lot of mistakes.
- 1.8** So if you can learn faster, it's better to do it. And you do that by studying other people who make choices, especially those who make choices with and for us in public life. So the study of statesmanship is important to getting good at forming your character. Now, what makes choices hard is not just, it's hard to know what the good is, what the best thing is. Aristotle says we actually always have a sense of that. If we didn't have a sense of it, we wouldn't be able to talk.
- 1.9** And I won't go through all of that argument except to say that this is a bottle. There are several different examples of bottles in this room, and yet we always recognize the bottle. That's why we can use common nouns, and that's why we can talk. But what do we recognize about the bottle? We recognize its essence, or its being, or its good. It's seeing the good that makes us able to do the one thing that only human beings do, which is talk.
- 1.10** We have grandchildren near us now, and I just love that. Also, they go home at night and don't keep us up. But they're learning to talk, and they long to do that. The 18-month-old is getting pretty good at it now, and that means she won't shut up, and we don't want her to, because it's just like a plant growing. They want to grow. Well, this is a drive in us, a fundamental drive. It's a unique drive to us. And so we see good all the time. We think it's controversial. No, we name it every time we use a common noun.
- 1.11** But the good is not enough, because you can't usually do just the good thing, because the goods are in conflict with each other. And you typically have to do your best, which means accepting something less than the best good or accepting something less than the worst evil. And that's what we call prudential or practical judgment. That's where our mental weather is all the time. Now, zoom that up from our little things, my little things, say, I had to make a decision whether to do this course. I do online courses for Hillsdale College, for which I am responsible. But I do this because I'm captivated by Jordan Peterson. And also, I love to talk about Winston Churchill.

- 1.12** So there was a good there that I was pursuing. And the obstacle was getting down here to Miami to do it. Worth it, I think. So there's an example there for us. Of course, what statesmen do is very consequential and matter to everybody. On the biggest scale, they matter to everybody in the world. And so it's not just plotting the future and deciding the state of the world. It's also an education to study statesmen and why they do it.
- 1.13** Now, because choices hinge on the good, but also necessity presented by circumstances. It means to study; choices means studying the circumstances; and that means you got to get into history. To know whether Winston Churchill was right about any particular thing, first of all, it's always a big argument because there are large numbers of people who think he was wrong about every single thing he did, and there are a few people who think that he was wrong about all of them.
- 1.14** But he was certainly wrong sometimes, according to my lights and according to his. And you have to know the circumstances. So, you study that to learn. I mean, you study it because it matters, because if you're a citizen, it's like plotting your own life and everybody else's. But you also study it to learn how to be better. And that's a very high calling and great. Most of you in the audience here are young. That means your characters matter very much. And there's still the forming, too.
- 1.15** How you live your life, one of Aristotle's doctrine is: you are what you do. And especially, you are what you choose to do. And as I said before, that's more important than actions we take because it's that moment of choice when the options are in front of you. He even goes further and says that the decisive thing about whether choices are good or not is for the sake of what you make them. You can see, courage is the first virtue discussed in the Ethics, and it's very visible in the rare cases where it's called for, especially on battlefields, because it's called for a lot on battlefields.
- 1.16** And you can see a picture, you can visualize one right now, of somebody doing something very brave, charging the enemy, going to save a fallen colleague. That might not be courageous because it also depends on why it was done. If it was done out of panic or if it was done to get a medal, Aristotle says that the decisive quality of an action and its quality is if it's done for the sake of the beautiful. And that's a term of art in Aristotle and classical philosophy in general. Good is what everything is. If it is a thing, beautiful is a high thing perfected. Aristotle says, "We long for the beautiful."
- 1.17** One of the reasons to study Winston Churchill is to look for evidence of the beautiful. I'm a partisan. I'm just kind of partisan. I'm a partisan after 40 years of study. I think that Winston Churchill was a very beautiful man. The young ones here don't know this yet, but your life is going to be dominated by a series of accidents. Mine is. I was compelled to take a course in undergraduate school. I was on my way to being a lawyer. I was ambitious and full of spit and going to go to a great law school. I was forced against my will to take a course in Plato, ancient political philosophy.

- 1.18** It just messed me up something awful. I tried to get out of it. I was a good student, and so it's a shameful thing. I'm so grateful to a lady named Susan Power, who was the chairman of the department at Arkansas State University. I went to her and said, "I don't want to take this course. I don't need it. I've done well here." Can you just hear me? Young jackass talking like that. She said, "Shut up and take the course." Well, it was dominating. I didn't go to law school. I went to graduate school.
- 1.19** And I studied Aristotle and Plato and such, and modern political philosophy, too. And I studied Abraham Lincoln and Winston Churchill. And studying Churchill was another accident. I've always had boxer dogs. We have the two worst boxer dogs in history right now, and they're both young and awful. And the first one was always getting in dogfights, and I was breaking up a dogfight, and I got bit by the enemy dog. I got a little mark right there. I can prove it. And my hand swelled up really big, and I was bedridden. I treated it with some vet medicine that I had for my dog.
- 1.20** And the person I was house-sitting for that summer had written his doctoral thesis on Winston Churchill, and I couldn't get out of bed, and all the books were there. And so I leaned over and got one and started reading it. I've been reading it—that was in 1975, I think—and I've been reading it ever since. So it's fun. I mean, I commend it to you. It's also hard. You have to know this. Abraham Lincoln was in active politics for eight or nine years. Winston Churchill was in active politics for just about 50 years, and he did some very consequential things outside politics.
- 1.21** He wrote almost 50 books. His speeches, which he wrote himself, they're published in, about this wide on a shelf, tall books, closely printed, 8,000 pages. And he wrote almost, well, we know of two speeches somebody wrote for him. He didn't like it. That's more than everything we have from Abraham Lincoln, more than a lot. And since this prudence involves the circumstances, with Churchill, there's a heck of a lot of circumstances to know.
- 1.22** And so, I was young and stupid, and I fell in love with this. I can recite the first paragraph I ever read by Churchill. It's the first paragraph of one of his greatest books, called *The World Crisis*. And I just never stopped, and I didn't realize what a difficulty I'd enroll myself in until it was a big difficulty. I helped to write the official biography of Winston Churchill, beginning in 1977. Got a fellowship, went to England, met the biographer, a great man named Sir Martin Gilbert. I met my wife in his house. She sits back there. We have four children and two grandchildren. All that comes from this dog bite.
- 1.23** Just remember, Churchill writes in the *World Crisis*, he's trying to describe how to understand the First World War, which is the worst thing that ever happened until the Second World War. And he thought it was a horror, and he even predicted it was. And he fought it. Fought in the trenches in it, fought as a senior cabinet minister in it. He says in the second volume of that book, it's a six-volume work, he says, "Huge, gigantic

forces. They seemed completely out of control." And they were, most of them. Nobody could stop it. Nobody could win it, really. Everybody was exhausted by it.

- 1.24** He said, but, "Along the pathway where footsteps are decisive, who knows when he may set a stone rolling or take or omit some seemingly ordinary step that will change everything." Now, if you think about that quote, which is one of my favorites of Churchill, there are several like it. What he's saying there is that if you can figure out where that place is, "the line of commanding causation," he calls it, you could change everything. But beware, because along that line, you may just by accident set a stone rolling that changes everything.
- 1.25** I'm going to explain that a little more next time, but art and chance are opposites, and yet they're also associates. That's why accidents are going to dominate your life, except they're not as important as what you make of them. OK, so I started studying all that, and I have studied it now continuously since 1975, I think. I went to England. I met this very great man, Sir Martin Gilbert. He's dead now. I thought he would be like Neville Chamberlain, which is how I pictured a British person. In fact, he was a little Jewish guy. He's a really great guy and a man of huge capacity. And so I learned to study history with him.
- 1.26** And then the official biography of Winston Churchill is the longest biography ever written of anyone. There are eight big, fat 1,200-page narrative volumes. And then there are—I can't even remember the number anymore—31 document volumes, all the documents in the Churchill archive, which are very, very many. And Martin Gilbert eventually died, and I personally edited the last seven of those, but I was involved in all of them. So, I've been working on it for a long time, and yet I will make plenty of mistakes today. Churchill liked to say, "We will not repeat the mistakes of the past. We will make new mistakes."
- 1.27** What kind of guy was Winston Churchill? We're going to talk about Churchill's early years mostly, today. They're just captivating to me, and anybody, really. There's a couple of good movies made about them. They're both made out of his best early book, *The River War*. He also wrote a book called *My Early Life*, which is a good way to start. Churchill had an art that we miss painfully today, and that is, he could praise himself without seeming to. He really very much does not do that unless you read closely. Nobody likes to hear long speeches about how great I am.
- 1.28** But he was born the eldest son of the second son of a duke, and the duke is the highest rank outside the royal family. They haven't made a dukedom, a new one, except for members of the royal family in 200 and some years now. At the end of his life, they offered one to Churchill, which he turned down. But his father was the second son of the Duke of Marlborough. And the Duke of Marlborough was the seventh, at that time, descendant of John Churchill who, along with Wellington, is the greatest English general. He just led Louis XIV on a dance. He always won. You can say that about almost no generals. He always won.

- 1.29** And Churchill wrote a great book about him. And he was actually born, Churchill— it was an accident. He never lived in Blenheim Palace. Blenheim Palace is one of the greatest houses in the world. And it was written to commemorate the Battle of Blenheim, which was, if memory served, in 1702. But I always confuse that. Maybe it was 1704. And it was the decisive thing that meant that France was never going to dominate Europe fully. And it was a wonderful battle. You should read about it. Churchill's book about it is really great.
- 1.30** He was born there because his parents were hunting, that means riding horses, looking for foxes, for a weekend. And his mother was hunting on a horse, and that provoked her labor. And so he was born in that place. Now, that means, by the way, that Churchill was born into the high circles of an aristocratic country. But there were two disadvantages that he had, despite that. And one was the Duchy of Marlborough is not rich.
- 1.31** In fact, the way great families keep their fortune together with the death duties, they call them in England the way they are, is they have to make a lot of money during their lifetime because every generation, they got to pay a bunch of tax. The Duke of Westminster, related to Churchill, owns much of Mayfair, which is the sweetest part of London. They got a lot of money. They can pay the death duties. The Marlboroughs didn't have a lot of money, and that means that Churchill didn't inherit a lot of money. Some money, but not a lot.
- 1.32** And the other thing was, he didn't get a title. Being the eldest son of the second son means he wasn't Lord anybody. And so he's up there and not at the top. And that meant it was good for him, I think, because he was very energetic and he made very great deal of money writing books. Twice in his life, he proceeded to lose most of that in the American stock market. But that was a setback. He went to school, ended up at Harrow, which is, after Eton, the most famous boys' school in England.
- 1.33** And he was a student of mixed success. Mixed, he was not at all good at doing things that he didn't want to do. He was stubborn and distracted. He would play with soldiers for hours. Learning Latin, he makes a big deal, in *My Early Life*, about how he couldn't learn any Latin. We have his school records. He actually did pretty well in Latin. But you can see, by the way, a democratic statesman, why would he make a big deal about the fact he couldn't learn Latin? It's comfortable. I like him better knowing that.
- 1.34** So he did pretty well in school. He took examinations to go on. He didn't do well enough to get into Oxford or Cambridge, so the military. And he didn't do well enough on the exams to go to infantry, which was cheaper for his dad, who was not rich; he got into the cavalry. His dad, who was a great politician whose career ended in a plummet — I won't tell you that story, but it's an interesting story. And his dad, generally and often, disapproved of Winston Churchill. That's a big thing in Churchill's life.

- 1.35 He loved his dad. He wrote a two-volume book about his dad, Lord Randolph Churchill. I don't think the book is particularly good, and I tend to like everything Winston Churchill writes, but it's an homage. He admired him a lot. And so his dad excoriated him for not getting into the infantry. But the minute Churchill got on the back of a horse, he was happy. He just loved the military academy. He writes beautifully about it, charmingly about it. "Nothing is so good for the inside of a boy as the outside of a horse. Boys have been ruined by owning horses and by betting on horses, never ruined by riding horses, unless they fall off, which taken at the gallop is a pretty good way to go."
- 1.36 And so he was a young man, and he was in the cavalry. And now I have to tell you a little bit about the late 19th century. That's the peak of British power. They have possessions all over the world. The possessions all have populations and neighbors. There are lots of fighting. The fighting all operates on a pretty small scale. Churchill loved that. He thought that was a huge advantage because we get to go out and fight. Not many of us are killed, and it's fun, and it makes us better people. He thought that.
- 1.37 Churchill was really good at war. I mean, on a battlefield, he was a lethal human being, without a lot of animus. And in the cabinet rooms, when wars are going on, he was cool. He could make great things happen under pressure. But his first taste of war was in these little imperial wars. He fought in—what's it? Got to name them. He fought first in Afghanistan, then in North Africa, in Sudan, and then in South Africa in the Boer War. And there was a side trip in there where he was sent as a spy to observe the rebellion in Cuba. He wrote a lot about that, but he didn't write that he was a spy. It's now known that he was, the war office sent him off there.
- 1.38 Well, he just liked battle. The first time George Washington was exposed to gunfire, he writes in a letter, "I heard the bullets whistle, and believe me, there was something charming in the sound." Churchill wrote to his mother, "There's nothing more exhilarating than to be fired upon without effect." And he was never wounded. He was in a lot of battles, and he was never wounded. The first campaign he took part in was in Afghanistan. He wrote a book about it called the Malakand Field Force. The books, he wrote three books about these wars, and each of them was a bestseller. He could write.
- 1.39 He was a second lieutenant, and the books would contain criticisms of generals. And they were the most famous books. His newspaper columns, for which he was paid a lot of money in those days, but a lot, significant amounts, they were one of the prime sources of information about the wars, and here's this second lieutenant. So they passed a rule in the British Army that you couldn't write for the papers if you were a serving officer. And so what he would do is resign his commission, write a bunch of articles, and then join back up. Incredibly annoying.
- 1.40 The great thing, there's a photograph of this scene I'll describe to you in the official biography. At one end of governing London is the Houses of Parliament and Big Ben. At

the other end of the street that comes all this off there called White Hall is Trafalgar Square. And if you walk from Big Ben to Trafalgar Square and look on your left, there's Downing Street. And a little ways down, look on your right. There's the war office. It's not called that anymore. It's now the Ministry of Defence, and it's bigger and not located all there anymore.

- 1.41 But what it was like, when it would be in the newspapers, that one of these imperial wars had broken out, was that there'd just be mobs of young soldiers standing around outside the war office, hoping to catch a sight of an officer so he could plead to be sent to the war. Because there wasn't really all that much fighting. The British Army was very officer-heavy because it was made— it's a great naval power; we'll talk about that next time—it was made to have a small army that could be expanded in case of need.
- 1.42 Well, the way to get up was to get close to the fighting. You can just see, these pictures are really great. Most of them are taken from the building next door, up pretty high, and they're just a sea of these officers. Well, Churchill was not among them. He didn't do it that way. Mostly what he did was, he just went to the place. And he figured out that, "When I get there, I'll know a lot of people and I'll get caught on."
- 1.43 The Malakand Field Force was a very popular book. And so he got asked by the Prince of Wales, who's the heir to the British throne, to come and talk to him about the book. And then later, about the same time, he got asked by the Prime Minister to come and talk to him about the book. So he got the heir to the throne and the ruling executive of the nation talking to Winston Churchill about his book.
- 1.44 And then they did what great men do when they meet ambitious young people. They said, "Anything I can do for you?" And Churchill gave the same answer to both of them. He says, "I want to go and fight in the Sudan against the Mahdi." It's really the first Islamic Republic that was tearing up the British Empire. They took the capital city Khartoum and they beheaded George Gordon, a great British Imperial figure, Chinese Gordon, they called him, because he was one of those guys who would just—he's one of the best of those guys who'd go around the world and just put an army together and fight a war and win it, usually. He didn't win in the Sudan.
- 1.45 And so everybody wanted to go to the Sudan. It was a great vengeance thing, too. I mean, because they beheaded a famous Briton in public. And you don't do that to us. Well, both the Prime Minister and the heir to the throne wrote to a man named Herbert Kitchener, very significant man in Churchill's life, and said, "We suggest you take young Churchill." And Kitchener replied to both of them, "No, I won't take him." So that would be definitive, wouldn't it? Well, Churchill just went anyway. And it's good that he went because he wrote his best early book about that thing.
- 1.46 And one of the two turning—I regard there are two things that are turning points in Winston Churchill's life. And the first one is here. He watched the Battle of Omdurman. And Omdurman is a plain outside Khartoum. And the structure of that war is that the

Nile is a thousand miles between Alexandria at the mouth and Khartoum along the way, closer to the source. And a lot of it is impassable, shallow. And so you can't get heavy equipment down there. And so you're going to fight a desert war. And that's what got Gordon killed.

- 1.47** There was a relief force. Herbert Kitchener was on the relief force, trying to get to Khartoum to save him. And they got chopped up in the desert by these Arabs who were better at the desert than the British. It was a camel corps trying to get there, a thousand miles. And so Kitchener was a very great logistical general. And so what he did was he loaded a bunch of equipment on boats. First, railway construction equipment. And he floated it down until the river got shallow, and he built a railway around the shallows.
- 1.48** And then he unloaded all the cars for the railway, and he loaded up all the army and the guns and the soldiers and the horses and two gunboats. And he took them down the railway till the river got deep again. And then he launched them all back again. Now they've got a modern army down there. And that means the battle is over. Now, Churchill writes somewhat harshly about the regime of the Mahdi and about Islam in that book. And there are many editions of that book, and the definitive one has just been published by a friend of mine named James Muller.
- 1.49** But some of the editions leave out some of the harshest things he says about the Muslims. And mind you, they're not racial things. He thought that religion, at that time in his life, and much after, I think, too, that that religion was not good for the people who practiced it. He thought Christianity was good for people who practiced it, unless it made them soft, which he entertained a time or two. Famous thesis from Edward Gibbon, British historian who wrote *The Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*. Churchill loved that book.
- 1.50** So, anyway, he doesn't like these guys, and he's in a war with them. But when he describes the decisive battle, the British—so, Khartoum is up to the north a little bit. They're on the plains of Omdurman. The river is at their back, which means that they're facing west. And the dervishes, they call them dervishes, are going to charge across about a mile of open ground. And they have artillery, and the first machine guns called maxim guns.
- 1.51** And when Churchill describes that, he says, "The white flags," I can quote it pretty well, "came over the ridge. They had no idea of the impending tragedy." They're going to kill them all before they get close. The dervish soldiers, the dervishes outnumbered the British about one and a half or two to one. The dervish soldier that got closest to the British line got 100 yards away. That means he couldn't see very well still. And he describes the charge, and he attributes great bravery to the dervishes, repeatedly in this description, and he describes what they're experiencing.

- 1.52** There's a paragraph, and this, I think, is a turning-point paragraph in Churchill's life. "They're charging. Bullets are whistling everywhere. Horses and soldiers are screaming with pain. Dust and heat and sweat and blood. And on they come still. When the flag goes down, somebody picks it up." Then, in the same paragraph, he switches to the British line. And what's that like? "Method, order. They're carrying ammunition for the guns. They're carrying water jackets to cool the barrels. After a while, the work became tedious, but they were interested in it. At each volley, there seemed to be fewer on the other end of the site. It's a factory."
- 1.53** Churchill hates that. He thinks that that—he wrote very much about this in his life. There's an essay he wrote in 1925, called "Shall we all commit suicide?" You have to know about Winston Churchill that he was a great warrior, and he feared war all his life after this, and he never took it lightly. "Mankind has never been in this position before. Without improving appreciably in virtue or enjoying wiser guidance, it has got into its hands at last the means of its own destruction. Death stands waiting at attention, silent, expectant, waiting for a word from the frail being, so long his servant, now for once his master."
- 1.54** Now, I think he saw something there. And he thought, "This is not about courage anymore. This is about science." But science has been changed. The word science comes from the Latin, and it means to know. To be a scientist is to be somebody who knows. Technology is a different kind of word. It actually comes from the Greek word for art, *techne*, and it means making. To make a thing is not the same thing as to know a thing. To know a thing is to accept the thing. Let the thing talk to you. See what the thing is. Whereas to make a thing is to render it.
- 1.55** And so, human making has got to the place where courage doesn't matter as much on a battlefield. Who knows how to build a railroad? Who knows how to build a machine gun? Who knows how to transport them down there where they can get used? And as I say, Churchill didn't like the dervishes. He didn't like this battle. He didn't like Lord Kitchener. Wasn't his kind of general, a logistical general, the guy who throws steel at people to win. And so, that was a change.
- 1.56** Now, the book was a bestseller. And after that, he goes to South Africa. At the Battle of Omdurman, he took part in the last big cavalry charge of the British Army, because the river is running down this way and the British are facing that way. And in the end, the dervishes were very brave soldiers and very competent. I mean, they threw the British out of Sudan. That wasn't easy. And on the other hand, they didn't understand. And so they fought them across an open plain with all that. But then they're not stupid and they figure out pretty quick, "We'd better get back to the city." And Kitchener figures out pretty quick, "We got to beat them back to the city."
- 1.57** And so now there begins a series of skirmishes where everybody is in motion. And those are fair. The only place where Churchill ascribes bravery to the British Army was during these skirmishes, in one of which he was. And he talks about—there's a cavalry

charge. And the desert, it undulates, but you can't see it all the time. And so they see some dervishes and "let's go get them. We got our horses, we got our sabers, we got our guns, we're going to ride them down." And they reach the dervish line and they figure out that there's a depression, and there's a lot more of them down there in the depression. And so they charge through them, take a lot of casualties.

- 1.58** Churchill had hurt himself getting onto a boat, messed up his shoulder. And so he was carrying a pistol. He couldn't swing a saber as well as he had been able to. So he noticed the way these battles go. In a battle where it's a lot of people fighting directly against each other, there's a lot of brave souls who come up to attack the weak ones. So, if your reins get caught or your horse is bleeding or you're bleeding, a lot of people come forward to challenge you. Whereas he, several times, somebody came up to him and he just shot him in the face with a pistol. Not so many came. Human nature has its ways.
- 1.59** Anyway, he got through that, as he did everything. And you see, just think about the difference between those two stages of the battle. Because in one stage, they're not really in contact with each other, and they're working a machine. And that's different. That's not the same thing. And that means that, when it took a lot of courage to win a war, there was a check on how bad war could get. And if it's technology, there may be checks. We've had decades to think about that now since the atomic bomb, which, by the way, Winston Churchill helped to invent, and hated every step of the way. But it's not the same.
- 1.60** Wellington would say famously that "the Battle of Waterloo was won on the playing fields of Eton." In other words, those boys grew up playing hard games, and that was good for them. Hard games is not enough now, and that's some decline in the world. And there's a thing to learn about Winston Churchill. There's a lot of horrors that he predicted that it was his fate to lead his nation through. And he didn't really have much choice about that, given what he was, which was willing. He was always ready. So he learned a lot from that.
- 1.61** And then he went down to South Africa. That was not a good war. It went on too long. The Boers, Churchill writes of that war in a book called *London to Ladysmith*, and he figured out while he was down there what the war was about, because why are we fighting? We've been both living here for 300 years without fighting. Why are we fighting now? And he says around the campfire, he has a conversation with some Boers, and that they can never accept the British claim of the equality of the "kaffir," which means mostly mixed-race people in South Africa, and that that was what the war was about.
- 1.62** And Churchill says, "Britain can't give that up." So it's a big war and it goes on a long time, and it wasn't understood to be a universal success. Kitchener was commander in that again, and he introduced the concentration camp, which wasn't quite the same

thing as what the Germans did, because those were factories for murdering people. But not a good thing. Round up a bunch of people, put them in a camp, and they did that.

1.63 And so he's there, and he did one very significant thing that made his political career, along with these books and other things he did. He was, by now, he was skirting the law about soldiers writing. And so he was not a soldier. He was a reporter on a given day. And a fellow named Haldane says, "I'm going to go on the armored train. Come with me." And Churchill had been on that train and didn't think it was a good idea and didn't want to go, but he was prevailed on to go.

1.64 And first of all, an armored train, wouldn't that be vulnerable? And so, this track that they were on went off to another town, and the track ended, so they had to come back on the same track. So everybody knew where it was going to be. And it went through a valley with rocky hills on the other side, and the Boers stacked up some rocks on the track and got some artillery and machine guns, and fired on the train and ran it into the rocks and derailed it. And there they are, out in the middle of nowhere, nowhere to go.

1.65 And so the armored train is armored, and the soldiers are mostly staying in the train. And Churchill is a journalist, but he gets out of the dang train, and he walks a big circle around it, and he looks, and there's bing, bing, bing, bullets have fallen, and everybody's staring at him, what? He comes back and he says, "Hey, we can get this thing loose." Haldane, who knew him, said, "OK, have a go." And he recruits a bunch of people, and for about an hour, they work, and they move the rocks, and they get the engineer to bump the rocks, and they get it loose. Just the locomotive, though.

1.66 And so they pile up the wounded on the locomotive, and their idea is that the train is going to go slow and the soldiers are going to run behind it. But the engineer can't quite make that happen. At one point, by the way, the engineer who was wounded was just going to give up. And Churchill said to him, "Buck up, man. No one is ever wounded twice in the same battle. And now you're going to get a medal." And Churchill did put in for the medal for him. Didn't get it. And so when Churchill became a cabinet minister, later he gave him the medal. You remember things like that.

1.67 Well, they couldn't make the train go slow enough. And so the men got left, and Churchill was on the locomotive, but he jumped off and said, "Well, I'm going to go with these guys." And so they get captured. As soon as the action is over, that is to say, getting the train loose, Churchill thanks Haldane with some interesting words. He says, "Thank you for letting me do that." Now, he's been under gunfire for an hour. Several were killed, many more wounded. He was not either killed or wounded.

1.68 He said, "The whole Derbyshire Light Infantry saw that, and now I will be elected to Parliament." And he was. But he gets caught, and then they're made to march for several hours, partly in the rain. They get to another railhead, they get on another train, and they go to Pretoria, the capital. And there's a photograph of Churchill.

There's a photograph of the officers dragged off this train, and they're in the middle of Pretoria, a big city. I just love this photograph. It's in the Churchill biography.

- 1.69 The burghers of Pretoria are lined up in a big semicircle, gawking at them. And the soldiers are a bedraggled bunch off to the side. And then here's Winston Churchill dressed somewhat differently. And he's off to the side. And I'll show you. I don't look like Winston Churchill, although I am exactly the same height he was. I guess I look like Winston Churchill later in his life. But he's standing like, most of the soldiers stand like this. Churchill is standing like this. He's defiant except casual. It's not a big deal to him, the way it looks.
- 1.70 I wrote about that one time. I said, "If Hitler had seen that photograph, he might not have made the mistake of turning his back on Britain and attacking Russia." Because he just was—and then by the time he got off this train, which they were on for several hours, he talked to the guards who were pointing guns at him the whole time, and he found out a bunch of stuff. And what he found out is, you're going to be taken to the state-model schools, which was a semi penitentiary, and that's where the officers are, and the enlisted men are in the stadium, camping out.
- 1.71 And so Churchill gets them to tell them how far it is between them. And so he arrives with a plan, which is to overpower the guards, march to the stadium, liberate the soldiers, take the capital, and end the war. Just the kind of thing. The commander of the camp wouldn't do it. And so, instead what he did was get away. He escaped. Another thing about, I said accidents. Accidents are a big thing with Churchill. He thinks that accidents and art go together, although they're opposites. Art is what you intend to do, you do artfully, you put skill into it.
- 1.72 Chance is—but it's an old teaching in classical philosophy that if there's room in the universe for a chance to be influential, then that means not everything is necessary. That's where art operates, too. So he gets away and he did many dumb things. He didn't have any water, he didn't have a good map, and he's exhausted. And finally, he sees a mining camp, and he goes into the camp and he's desperate. He's got to knock on the door.
- 1.73 And he didn't know it, but there were many houses in that camp. And there was one house in which resided British people, and that's the door he knocked on. And the guy hid him and eventually got him on a train to Mauritius, that's where it was, and he gets away. And then there are photographs of him. And this war is not going so great. And so he's a hero.
- 1.74 He ran for office two or three times, sorry, three times before he was elected. He was in many elections, and he won almost all of them, but not all of them. And he was persistent. He liked it. He liked war, although he feared it for the rest of his life, and he liked politics. He liked elections, although they were maddening for him. I have some letters that he wrote to a woman named Gladys Salmon, and she was a constituency

volunteer for him in Epping, which he represented from 1924 and for the rest of his life. The constituency changed its name, but it was the same place.

- 1.75** I was a Rotary fellow in England. And by chance, I was assigned to a Rotary club in Epping. And so the Rotarians, you guys know any Rotarians? They're cool. And they adopt me, and they know that I'm interested in Churchill. So I met everybody in that place who knew Winston Churchill, which Winston Churchill represented for 40 years. And I met a lot of people.
- 1.76** This Mrs. Salmon was the best. She was a spinster of a woman, small little lady and very old. And she loved these memories of Churchill, and she was a good witness. That's to say, if you're going to tell anybody what something's like, it's a good idea not just tell them what you think about it. Tell them what it was like. And so she was good at that. And what was going on in those years was that the Stanley Baldwin, Neville Chamberlain machine in the Conservative Central Office was trying to get Churchill deselected. That means he wouldn't have a seat in Parliament.
- 1.77** And that meant votes in a bunch of little places spread all over the Epping district, Theyden Bois and places like that. And they had little constituency groups, and they would meet and vote. Somebody had to go to those and talk to Churchill. And the grand person who did that was Sir Stuart Mallinson, whom I met. But the great person who did it was Gladys Salmon. And Winston Churchill and Clementine both wrote her letters.
- 1.78** And she would tell how exciting it was when Churchill would visit, which most of the work he didn't visit. He was busy, fighting the whole government about appeasement. But she was very excited about all that. And she could tell how, mostly what she related was, he was kindly. They say he would stop and pay attention to her and be grateful to her. The letters show that, too. That's the thing, a skill you should cultivate, a quality you should cultivate. That is to say, pay attention to people. Don't do important things when you're distracted by something else.
- 1.79** Anyway, she had these letters, and I said, "Oh, these are awesome, Ms. Salmon. You should leave those somewhere where they'll be preserved." And she said, "I want to give them to you." And I said, "No, ma'am, I don't think you should do that." I said, "I think you should put them in a museum or an archive, or you could sell them. They're worth money." And she said, "Would you sell them?" And I said, "Never." And she said, "That's why I want you to have them." So I have them today. I'm going to give them to the college, probably. It's got a Churchill archive.
- 1.80** If you think about this for a minute, in the formative years of his life, he's fighting and he's writing. And the writing becomes interesting. He can see things that not everybody sees. He can extrapolate. He concludes this time in his life believing that war is very dangerous, believing that Britain is very great, believing that its kindly intentions toward the people who live in it are fundamentally important, believing that that

system of government, that attitude and system of government, the principles behind it, are the best thing in the world and the biggest force in the world and worth fighting to preserve, although try to keep out the fighting.

- 1.81** Also, pretty soon in this time in his life, he begins to reflect that this technology and these destructive weapons are a natural product of free government made by that more than anything else. Why? Because people work and innovate, they act under their own authority, they make things stronger and better. And that means that free government contains the seeds of its own destruction, just like every human thing does. Abject tyrannies are not particularly innovative, but they're abject tyrannies. And free countries let people think, and that will produce strength, especially in this age of technology.
- 1.82** And so that's, you could say that, by the time he was 27, Churchill had identified that as a force and a contradiction that he would have to deal with for the rest of his life. He had completed his education by then, and that's how he got it, watching.
- 1.83** You mentioned two major turning points, and maybe we'll get to this eventually, but other than the Battle of Omdurman, what was the second?
- 1.84** He learned that the same dangers that were arriving in war were arriving in peace, too. The powers that let us turn the battlefield into a technological marvel and field of slaughter can also let us control people at home. Yeah.
- 1.85** You mentioned a few times that Churchill liked war. Of course, war is a tool and not an end within itself. Human beings have this tendency to conflate the means with the end. How do you think that Churchill guarded himself against letting his utilization of war become a glorification of it, in the same way that he divorced democracy as a means from being an end within itself, the least worst kind of government? He understood it as just the tool and not the end in itself. How did he do that with war?
- 1.86** OK, means and ends. Isn't that fun? Do you think that the ends justify the means? You don't? What does? Of course they do. Don't you do something every day that you wouldn't do, except for some end that's more important than that? The trouble is, the relationship is more complex than that. Means and ends are in a dance of a kind. I mean, here's one of the most horrific—no, here's two of the most horrific associations of means and ends in human history.
- 1.87** Let's say that you think that the Jews are an international people without state who interfere with the growth and achieving of greatness of any country. I will tell you that one of the greatest minds in the 20th century, the German philosopher Martin Heidegger, believed that. It's horrific, right? Then the next thing you know, that's an end. Let's say it's good. I don't happen to think so. But then the means adopted are to kill, to invent factories to kill people.

- 1.88 There's a wonderful movie called— what's it called? Outrage. It stars Kenneth Branagh, and it's about the Wannsee conference, where they devised the final solution. Now, that's a bad end and very bad means. But the ultimate end they were thinking about is that people would live in peace and harmony and grow excellence among themselves. Now, the other thing that's just like it is communist totalitarianism.
- 1.89 Aristotle writes that the fundamental question in politics, or controversy in politics, is between the few rich and the many poor. So, how do you handle that? Aristotle proposed a moderate way to go about it, which is rather like the way that it was adopted in the Federalist Papers, with some additional sophistications, in my opinion, in the Federalist Papers, which is, you ameliorate that in various ways. A lot of it has to do with giving people a chance.
- 1.90 But let's say, instead, you want to simply eliminate it. You want everybody to be the same. Well, they're not the same. And so they're not going to come out the same. But we get the idea that we can make them do that. And it takes a lot of making. My wife and I have four children, and they're all different. They're just not the same. And I think it's Penny's fault, but it's a very relentless force. So make them all the same, and that means you can't make an omelet without breaking eggs. You're going to have to kill a bunch of people.
- 1.91 So, those are bad ends and bad means. But the final end that they're after is something beyond that that everybody agrees with, which is, don't we all need to live in harmony and be able to fulfill ourselves and all that stuff? And then you can see that, in human life, you can't really perfectly get that. There isn't any—I believe, it's a long study, I believe, I argue, that the American Constitution is the best one ever written. I think that. But is it imperfect? Sure. It's for people, bound to be.
- 1.92 And so, it's like you guys are all devoted, I imagine, to the philosopher Jack Handey. He's the Saturday Night Live philosopher. You should read him. He's really smart. "I can imagine a world with no war and no weapons. And I can imagine us conquering that world because it'd be easy." It's like, that's a form—much of his humor is like this—it's a form of something that Aristotle and Thomas Jefferson and Winston Churchill all said. "You can force nature out the front door with a pitchfork, but it'll be back in the back door before you can turn around."
- 1.93 So, yeah, means and ends. It comes out, there's no cookie-cutter way to say the relationship exactly, because there are some things that you just can't do. Although if you study that, if you haven't read the Nichomachean Ethics, I suggest that you start this evening. It is one of the greatest books ever written, in my little opinion. And I've been reading it for a little longer than I've been reading Winston Churchill.
- 1.94 And what does he tell you about that? He tells you that you have to want the beautiful. That's the thing. But then how you go about that is a prudential decision. Takes time to think of it. It takes, circumstances have to be taken into account. What will be the

effect of what you do? Will it lead to greater harm? You can't perfectly know that. But yeah, so in other words, moderation is a great thing.

- 1.95** We'll talk about it next time, but there's one time in Winston Churchill's life that I know of where he went all the way, and that's in 1940. He thought the emergency was so serious that everything should be sacrificed in order not to submit to Hitler, whether you could beat him or not. You see, you can't join that cause. It'll be the end of you. You see, well, I can tell you, he resisted doing things like that furiously all the time. And he didn't, in the end, have to do that, but nearly got close.
- 1.96** So, yeah, Churchill, he learned these things. And how did he learn? Just like we learn, he could see, and he thought about it a lot. And by the way, he was a much better student than he ever let on. I didn't come here to praise or blame Donald Trump, but he talks about himself a lot, and the typical adjective's in the superlative. Mostly, I think it's funny, but you won't find that in Abraham Lincoln or in Winston Churchill.
- 1.97** He wrote an essay called *Painting as a Pastime*. It's one of the most important things he ever wrote. He was a painter. He had 16 solo exhibitions at the Royal Academy. Adolf Hitler, Dwight Eisenhower, George W. Bush, and Winston Churchill were statesmen painters. Churchill was actually a good painter. Look at the paintings. You can see. His are interesting, and they're pretty good.
- 1.98** Anyway, he does write a masterpiece about painting, and he says, "Painting is like fighting a battle, except more exciting. It's also like making a philosophic argument successfully. It's also like giving a wonderful speech. It's a work of art." And that doesn't mean it's the person who did it. It has a life of its own. If you notice, do you find it hard to write? It is hard to write. Very worthy, but it's very hard. And it's very hard because the minute you put a word on the page, it has a life of its own.
- 1.99** Now, everything that comes later has to go with that word. It's why you have to start over all the time. It's why writing is a learning experience. Because by committing yourself, by writing this much, now you have to think what goes with that. Painting is just the same. In *Painting as a Pastime*, he writes a lot about the fact that he's a painter. And they're just repeated references to the fact that he's not a very good painter. There's one claim of competence in there, in the middle of this most important paragraph.
- 1.100** And the paragraph is—studying Winston Churchill, by the way, is a school of writing because he learned how to do that, and he talked a lot about how to do it. One of the things he says is that, before you can be eloquent, you have to be clear. Say exactly what you want to say, and learn to say it in an order that will be available to the mind of the person who says it. It's the reason it's good to have you here when most people who see this are not here.
- 1.101** The paragraph begins, "Just to paint is great fun. The colors are lovely and delicious to squeeze out." Isn't that nice? I used to have a T-shirt with Churchill by an easel and

those words. I can't find it. I can't find where to buy one anymore either. I'm going to have to devise one. Anyway, that's what the paragraph is about. Because when you write, you announce the paragraphs, and one sentence follows on the other. Unless, by the way, you want to hide something.

- 1.102** And so he says, "But then, as one," I don't remember exactly the words, but it's like this, "as one advances in the art," a sort of claim of competence, "wider considerations come into view. One begins to see that painting a picture is like fighting a battle, if anything, more exciting than fighting it successfully." Now, hidden in a paragraph about delicious colors, he begins to talk about what it's really about.
- 1.103** And why would he hide that, by the way? He hid that for the reader. He wants you to know, "I'm not a braggart. You shouldn't be either." He wants you to know serious things hide among fun things. He's a teacher. It's very good. Anyway, then he talks about Turner, a real genius. Canvases yards wide and tall. Motion captured in an instant. Everything consistent, everything fits. You see what a work of art is now, right?
- 1.104** Turner liked to do sea battles. That's got to be the hardest thing. Everything is in motion. The wind, the sails, the ships, the sea, the cannon, everything is moving all the time. How would you paint that into a static picture? And yet, because he can do that, you can actually see a sea battle better in those paintings than you could ever see one in person because you'd never have the vantage point. And it's also fleeting, right? In other words, it's actually an improvement on reality. But before it can be an improvement, it has to be not a diminishment. And that's very difficult.

Lecture 2: Churchill on Governance

At a glance — Churchill on governance.

- 2.1 Churchill was a remarkably perceptive human being. And those are different. In this paragraph that I like, that I described in *Paintings as a Pastime*, he's trying to account for the phenomenon of genius. Turner had something the rest of us don't. What is that thing? Churchill was very interested in that. Churchill thought that the greatest commanders have that, too.
- 2.2 And so, as I've said, he doesn't apply that to himself, except very indirectly. I don't think it's just because he knew that was not a good way to be effective in politics. I think he regarded it as unseemly to honor oneself. That's for others to do. But here's an illustration. In *Marlborough: His Life and Times*, which I regard as one of Churchill's two best books— the two best ones, I think, are unfortunately long. They're multi-volumes. But if you want to read just one, read *My Early Life*.
- 2.3 But in *Marlborough: His Life and Times*, he describes— the chapter is called *The Structure of the War*. It's the beginning of Volume 2. What is the structure of this war? What weapons did they use? Where did they fight? How did they get around? Stuff like that. Then he says, "But I must now tell something that illustrates not one but many operations of war"—in other words, of general application. He says, "Why did Marlborough win all the time?" And he says, "It can't be a technique."
- 2.4 Because in war, there's just a few things you can do. If the enemy is here and you're here, you can go around or you can go at them or you can retreat. And there are variants of that, but you won't get as many as 30 different things you can do. Why do some people get it right? He says, "Circumstances alone," alone, that's an exaggeration, by the way, but "determine whether a particular maneuver will work. And the great commanders move their armies about as easily as other men ride their horses from place to place."
- 2.5 And then this, what follows is just like the thematic sentence in Plato's *Republic*. "Nothing but genius, the daemon in man, can answer the riddles of war. And because genius is much rarer than the rarest and purest of diamonds, wars are mainly tales of muddle." See that? Churchill never attributed that to himself, except by describing it. He achieved it, I think.
- 2.6 And see, here, that leads to a political problem, by the way, because, of course, you've all read Plato's *Republic*. The thematic sentence in that book might be, "The cities will be miserable until the philosophers are kings, and they won't be." Why would they? They're capable of better things than taking care of us. We're too ignorant to know who they are, so we can't make them. How would you make them anyway?

- 2.7** So it's interesting that it's comparable to Abraham Lincoln's first great speech he gave in 1838, if I remember the year right. It's a speech to the Young Men's Lyceum, which is a bunch of ambitious young men, mostly, I guess, men, getting together and talking about big things. And he says that—what is it? Something of the lion and the tribe of the eagle, the tribe of the lion and the something of the eagle, that those people are very significant people.
- 2.8** Then he asked the question, OK, but what do they use that for? Because they could use it to dominate. But that would be a diminishment of their greatness. If you're to rule people, you should rule them for their good, and then you can multiply good. Whereas, if you rule them for your good, you're truncating them. And why would that be just or right in any way?
- 2.9** You know what Hitler's—among his last words in the bunker was, "The German people have proved unworthy of me." It turned out, he thought he was God, but he did happen to die when he shot himself. In the study of politics large, you figure out that there are many different kinds of regimes and many different ways of kinds of peoples and cultures. How can you make sense of all that? What are the good kinds?
- 2.10** Well, it's much easier to say what the good kinds are than it is to say what the best kind is, because the best kind depends on circumstances, right? Here's Aristotle's taxonomy of the regimes. I want to say, it's legitimate to talk about Aristotle when you're talking about Churchill, because he read Aristotle, and one of the big influences on his life was the headmaster of Harrow School, where he went, his name was Welldon, who was a foremost translator of Aristotle back in those days.
- 2.11** Aristotle says that there are six kinds of regimes, and they are divided by how many rule and how they rule. And there are only two ways they can rule in the interest of the public or in the interest of themselves. Those are all flawed kinds, three of them. How many rule? One, few, or many. Monarchy is good rule by one. Tyranny is bad rule by one. Aristocracy is good rule by a few. Oligarchy is bad rule by a few. And then the word for good rule and bad rule by the many is the same word. They're both called democracy.
- 2.12** Well, that means that the question in politics is, how do you organize rule to be for justice in the public interest? Because rule is necessarily and is natural, by the way. We always live under laws, or else we're miserable. But very often the laws make us miserable, too. There's a reason why we're made for politics and law, according to Aristotle. I'll tell you what it is, if you want to know. If you become a public person or just a thinking citizen, you need to figure out, how do you make it good? Because the law is a very powerful force.
- 2.13** If you're somebody like Winston Churchill, who's an exceptional human being, there's a temptation to think that just "I should do it or people like me should do it." But you see, that won't work because there aren't very many people like him. The few there are,

they've got better things to do than force people to do stuff all the time. It's a great rule in life, by the way, not to have a relationship with anybody where you're making them do anything, because it's just troublesome and a pain, and you'll never know what resentments they're harboring. Whereas, anybody who thinks it's a privilege to work with you, you'll end up thinking it's a privilege to work with them, too. And that's the power of justice.

- 2.14** And Churchill knew that power. Churchill was a constitutional reformer, but he didn't get very much time for it. He wanted to make the British Constitution more like the American Constitution. He wanted to reintroduce bicameralism all his life. He wanted the House of Lords. He said, "You can't have hereditary rule in Britain or any modern country anymore. But you could have indirect methods of picking the House of Lords so that it would be a real body and indirectly representative." He was for that. He spent a lot of time thinking about that.
- 2.15** He made major proposals three times, and they never got anywhere. And part of the reason was, although he had about as long a career as it's possible for a human being to have, he didn't have time. He went into Parliament in 1900. Between 1900 and 1911, he switched to the Liberal party from the Conservative party. He claimed—he eventually switched back, too—but he claimed he always believed the same thing. "I'm a Tory Democrat," he always said, "standing for the Constitution and the sovereignty of the people under the Crown." And he worked all that out.
- 2.16** And then, that's my third, it's turning point 1.1. In 1911, he's busy building the social safety net, which he's one of the inventors of that, and I will tell you, I'm a conservative man. If we could get back the social safety net that Winston Churchill built, it would be a very good thing. Not just because it would restrict it, it would some, but it would encourage work. He was very big into that and rolling, right? And then he discovered something, and it changed the direction of his career.
- 2.17** He went to a briefing, and a man named Henry Wilson, who was a strategic planner in the British Army, he showed a series of presentations that showed, among other things, that the Germans were building very large rail capacity up to the Belgian border. Now, in 1914, the Germans would invade France and Western Europe through Belgium. But at the moment, and right up to that war, the Germans had a treaty with the Belgians that they wouldn't attack each other.
- 2.18** And if a third person attacked one of them, they would come to the defense, which means that they not only promised Belgium they wouldn't, but they also put in place a thing to encourage Belgium not to defend itself. And then they noticed that they were building concrete ramps beside major roads where the railway was close to the major road. And they couldn't figure out why the ramps were the distance apart they were. And then they figured out that that was the distance between the doors on two railway cars.

- 2.19** And so they were a place where a bunch of soldiers could arrive by truck and march up a ramp and go into railway cars. They were planning for the invasion of Belgium, and they were pouring concrete to do it. Churchill had warned in 1901, something he learned at the Battle of Omdurman, he warned that, "Wars of major powers will not be like anything we've ever seen. It will be hard to tell who wins. The exhaustion of the victors will match that of the vanquished, and every resource of the nation will be poured into them."
- 2.20** Because it's possible to do that now. It's not just technical weapons, it's also the massive organization of society. In the wars of Marlborough, around 1700, they couldn't really fight in the winter because they couldn't get enough food together to feed an army in the winter. And the roads were impassable. Now, you can go anywhere, anytime. And then the society is far advanced in its organization.
- 2.21** I personally resent that very much because I think that what we need to do for the schools is return them to the control of the teachers and the parents. Because school is not rocket science until it becomes rocket science, and that's later. And what it is before that is math and more elementary science. And that's not rocket science. Millions of parents teach their kids successfully at home. Why do you need all this bureaucracy? I'm against that.
- 2.22** But it's organized now, and it's organized in part under the idea that if we bring science and expertise to bear on it, it'll be a lot better. The trouble with that—and by the way, when it's true, it's powerfully true. But what does that leave anybody to do? What place is there for you if you can't raise your own kids?
- 2.23** Churchill was beaten by the socialists in 1945 after the Great War. Then there was a man named Mr. Douglas Jay, who was in the Home Office, a member of Parliament, and he said, made the terrible mistake, he's famous for it, of saying, with Winston Churchill in the House of Commons to hear it, that something to the effect, as a paraphrase, "Mothers do not always know what is best for their children, I think, to eat. The gentlemen in Whitehall know better."
- 2.24** You see, well, if you have to be an expert to raise your kid, what is there in life for you to do? It also divides your life up into little bits because nobody, nobody can be an expert on very many things. I know a lot about Winston Churchill, and what that means is, perforce, there are many things that I don't know much about. Whereas the practical work of going about your life, can you live a fully human life?
- 2.25** So that's in an essay called Mass Effects in Modern Life, which he wrote in 1932. He talks about this. He talks about the fact that everything is done in a massive way now. And that means it's all tailored and not tailored, it's all mass-produced. Even the news, he says, he complains. Boy, is it not like that way now? And so where's there room for one to live and have a life? "What has caused this?" he says. "It is science," he says.

What he really means is technology, by the way, because I told you what those words mean.

- 2.26** We have been conscripted. It feeds us. It takes care of us when we retire. It teaches us. Never has a generation of men been so handled like this. Well, firstly, you need to figure stuff out for yourself, because if you step back from the sophisticated current age, human nature has not changed at all. Everybody in this room knows that he or she is going to die. We're the only beings that know that, who are going to die. And so the quality of our lives is an urgent question which becomes more urgent with age.
- 2.27** And in addition to that, the quality of our lives is powerfully affected by our choices. And we are made to make those choices under difficulty. Everything is hard in life. And so, do you face that? This wish to take all that away is, Churchill believed, not good for us. Here's an interesting thing. Late in his life, in his second premiership, by now, there's a department of education, the Ministry of Education. Never had one before. Ours was born in America in 1979. So, very late. And they wanted to do a curriculum, and he held it up. They wanted to do a curriculum for adult education, and he held it up until they would add in an encouragement and a focus on the classics.
- 2.28** Why? He says he understands that those are fundamental. And he says, "What a joy laid in your life to take up the serious questions about life that are raised first in the classics." That's what he thought, right? What do we think when we think of adult education now? We think of that sometimes. Also, we think of skills and trades, and we think of amusements. The truth is, the most amusing thing is the question, "What are we? What are we for?" In other words, standardization, which makes plenty, and you can't do without it, by the way.
- 2.29** If Churchill were a utopian, you can just tell by the way he writes about the atomic bomb, about modern weapons, about the way war changed, about socialism, which he regards as a, it's the peacetime equivalent of modern weapons in war. You can control everything now. You can see he hates that, but you can't do anything about it, except remember that it can't answer the most serious questions. And teach that and focus on that, because let's say we're going to swear off modern weapons. You're going to fight the Russians and the Chinese with spears? And there's no choice.
- 2.30** So it means, by the way, that it places your life in an effort to live a civilized life of meaning amidst all this. And also, when you think like a citizen, how do we organize things so that everybody gets a chance to do that? And that's what Winston Churchill did all his life. He thought, in the end, the British people are the best judge and have a right to rule. How do you keep that alive when things are so centralized and automated? That's a big question, and he asked it over and over.
- 2.31** In *Mass Effects in Modern Life*, there's a very gloomy paragraph where he says, "They've been taken—mass effects have been taken to their extreme in the Bolshevik state." And he concludes the paragraph. He says, "They conscript everything. The

individual is a function of the state." And then he says, "The model for this society is not the bee, because this society can make no honey. The model for this society is the white ant." That is where human progress has taken us. We are modeling ourselves on the white ant.

- 2.32 By the way, if you want to see that argument made in a different way, a very great book by C.S. Lewis is called *The Abolition of Man*. It's a tremendous achievement, that book, and so is this essay by Churchill. But then the next sentence— and this is very typical of Churchill—the next sentence is one of the most hopeful things he ever wrote. He says, "But human beings are more intractable than ants. The explosive variations in human nature do something." He says, "It is at once the safeguard and the glory of mankind that it is easy to lead and hard to drive." You see?
- 2.33 When I was interviewed to be the president of the college, and by the way, anybody in this room who wants to be a college president can be. There's a thousand jobs a year, and they're not very good jobs. I'm in this room, and there's an MBA guy, and he says, "How did you learn how to manage?" I said, "Well, various ways." I said, "One that you will like probably won't matter." He said, "What?" I said, "Peter Drucker, who's the inventor of modern management science, used to be my landlord." He goes, "What?" I said, "Yeah, I know him well. I liked him a lot, too, but I never studied with him."
- 2.34 I said, I learned how to manage by making mistakes and trying not to make them again. Churchill loved to say, "We will not repeat the mistakes of the past. We will make new mistakes." The other is, "I read Winston Churchill and Aristotle," and he said, "What did you learn from them?" I said, well, he was Churchill. He wrote English. "It is the safeguard and the glory of mankind that it is easy to lead and hard to drive." See? And Churchill figured that out. I mean, we're going to talk about Churchill and Empire next time. But Churchill was an imperialist. He didn't want to be making people do things all the time.
- 2.35 How are those two things compatible? Well, he wrote a lot about that. You see? And that means we've talked some about colleges and how they work. The word college just means partnership. And the first paragraph of Aristotle's *Politics* says, just as the first sentence of Aristotle's *Ethics* says, "Every action, choice, inquiry, and art seems to aim at some good. Therefore, it has been beautifully said that the good is that for which all things aim." The first paragraph of Aristotle's *Politics* says, "Every community is formed for the sake of some good." And you can't have a community unless you have that in common.
- 2.36 And colleges are old things, many of them. And if you go back to the beginning of any old one, you always find some beautiful thing that it was said to be for. How many of them pay attention to that these days? But in other words, to get together and work together, you need to be in agreement about the end. And since colleges proceed by argument and evidence and proof, the whole place is just going to be one big grand

argument all the time. But that need not be divisive if we've agreed about where we're trying to go. And you're not supposed to be full of resentment.

- 2.37 Well, Churchill understood that about all human relations, and Aristotle did, too. We should agree on the end. And it's when we disagree about the ends that we get into wars. Yeah.
- 2.38 Hillsdale people often talk about the good and the true and the beautiful. And you opened this course up by calling Churchill a beautiful person. And you went so far as to say that he wasn't always right, and maybe he wasn't the most virtuous person, but he was a beautiful person. And so, I guess my question is, what is it about Churchill that made him beautiful? What about the essence of beauty did he reflect, and how can we all become beautiful through imitating him?
- 2.39 Well, first of all, I think you can't be beautiful without being virtuous, although we all have faults. And to be beautiful is not to be divine. God is just beauty, and it—in Aristotle's philosophy and in Thomas Aquinas and Augustine, all of them, God is just beauty. He's just the thing. That's what beauty is. The rest of us might achieve some beauty or be beautiful in some way.
- 2.40 So, yeah, what was beautiful about Churchill? There's a description of Julius Caesar in the play by Shakespeare. "He was sanguine, and the elements were so mixed up in him that all the world could look at him and see that here was a man." Churchill was very brave. I mean, personally brave on the battlefield, but very brave in council. Churchill was moderate. He was always looking for a way where the people and he could take the least punishment. He was just. He was sympathetic, I think. So there's just a whole bunch of qualities.
- 2.41 And then, what his life is, because remember when you're studying— if you're studying Plato, he was a thinker, pretty good at it. And that means he's telling you things in principle as a staple of his work. This is how it is. The great question in Greek philosophy is "ti esti?" What is it? What is? What is that thing? If you read the Socratic Dialogues, Socrates is very annoying because he turns every question into, "What is the meaning of that thing?" You say this, what is the meaning of that proposition? How does everything else work if this is like this? Where does it fit? It's just relentless. They killed him for it, and he had it coming.
- 2.42 But when you read a statesman, the advice is said in a context, and they're responsible for the context. And so Churchill never wrote a philosophic treatise, although he got close in many places. And so you have to divine amidst it all. I don't know if you know the importance of Shakespeare, but I'll tell you. At the end of the Symposium, Socrates makes a point, right at the end, that there would be a poet who could write tragedy and comedy, and that would be the greatest poet. Well, Shakespeare did both those things, and he wrote those history plays. If you're interested in British history, and why not, you have to read the story of what happened, of course.

- 2.43 But to get to the meaning of it, to get what moved people, what did they think, what placed them in action, there's nobody like Shakespeare for that. And you know, those plays are tragedies. British history is one of the happiest histories in human experience. And it's also a long string of tragedies, like our history. It's not the worst, but it's pretty bad often, because they come to find out human things. They are the way they are. OK, anything else?
- 2.44 Yeah. Was politics the best route for Churchill to go down to maximize his impact on law?
- 2.45 Sure, yeah. Impact, right? It means pound it, make an impression. Yeah, that, for sure, except that thing he said. "Nail your life to a cross of thought or action." Who's the most influential, Churchill or Socrates or Jesus? That depends. I mean, in some ways, Churchill, but not many. Shakespeare, right. You have to remember that Churchill was an author, and he won the Nobel Prize for literature, and he deserved it. He didn't actually deserve it as much for the book that won it, *A History of the English-Speaking Peoples*.
- 2.46 So I'm about to make the argument that understanding is superior to doing. Doing is necessary. We have to do. I'm critical of the good, the true, and the beautiful school when they think it doesn't include any action. But here we've got all these bodies and stuff, and we have to take care of them. So nail your life to a cross of thought or action. Who would you rather be, Plato or Churchill? It's a hard choice.
- 2.47 Plato is a higher human type, I think, but not a lot—and here's the argument for that. If it's true that philosophers will not be kings and cannot be, then philosophers themselves are at risk because people often don't like them. They're weird and different. How are they to be protected? The answer is, the virtue exercised by statesmen is dual-sided. It's looking at the good in an ultimate sense, and it's looking at the circumstances. But that means it's participating, to some extent, in the work of philosophers, and yet it's practically effective. The statesman is the guardian of the wise. And you need that.
- 2.48 I have a question.
- 2.49 Yeah.
- 2.50 Pretend that we're in the fantasy world and you can only be either Winston Churchill or the King. Which one would you prefer to be, and why?
- 2.51 Oh, that's easy. I want to be Winston Churchill.
- 2.52 Well, I mean, first of all, kings are not very interesting. What they are is people who are well-born. There have been some really great kings, most of them not. The limit on monarchy, the reason monarchy is a powerful attraction and can be really good is that it's easy to identify who's in the family. I mean, by the way, it's not uniformly easy, but is that person really legitimate? That's a way to go. That's how you pick them. But then

what you find out is, brilliant people have kids who are idiots and vice versa. So it's not the best.

- 2.53** What is the best? Churchill wants to find aristocracy, which is, literally means two Greek words, rule of the best. He says that democracy, democracy is the association of us all in the rule of the best. And that means, the advantage is we can pick from anybody. Every being wants to do its work. It's made to. Birds want to fly. Bees want to buzz, I guess. People want to exercise their capacities. They're born with them.
- 2.54** Here's the great lesson of that is—I used to know the guy who ran the Santa Anita racetrack, where a lot of famous things happen in the horse-racing world. And I visited the track one and I found out about John Henry, a great horse. And the thing about John Henry was, he wanted to run and he wanted to win. And that meant, on every day except race day, he was everybody's friend. He had his head out of the stall looking, nuzzling around for sugar, and all that stuff. On race day, he was dead earnest, so much so that he would hardly look up when he was fed and when he was dressed for the race.
- 2.55** When he went out the thing, he just looked straight ahead, stallions around, he didn't care. He was thinking to himself, "In a few minutes, I'm going to beat that guy." He loved to run. And that's why he was so good. By the way, every racehorse movie, every horse-racing movie that's ever been made, is a great movie. And they're all exactly the same. This horse was born to run. There's a bunch of obstacles. Then he wins the big race at the end. How can you not like that? See, that's because it's his nature, made to run.
- 2.56** Well, we are like that, too. We want to exercise our capacities, all of them. And one of our capacities is the capacity for rule, because ruling ourselves is in principle the same thing as ruling others. And if we get generous enough to understand what that means, it means that you should help in the rule of others and let them rule themselves, too, you see. So we all want that. And that's why kingship—you know, in the best understanding of kingship, and Britain, by the way, has had—Britain is the second-greatest country in the world. They've had an excellent—I mean, first of all, Elizabeth II. Wow. Elizabeth I is the greatest, but Elizabeth II is up there.
- 2.57** And why? She's a servant, and she has iron self-discipline, and she's exercised it for a long time now. I will mourn her passing. I've learned to do that from my wife. So, yeah, there's a lot of attractions to monarchy. But in the end, the sacrifice in it is serious because, especially now, you're not going to get to rule. You're going to have to go around and be honored for the rest of your life. That would be boring, I think. So it takes real discipline to do it.
- 2.58** Being so familiar with Churchill, how would you think—so you mentioned that he would quit the service and then write and then he'd do it less. How do you think that he would approach some of these things that we face today with cancel culture or our

education system? What strategies would he try to implement or take on in some of these events that we see currently?

- 2.59** Well, Churchill, it wouldn't be fair to say that Churchill thrived in the British education system of his day. It was too strict and too confining for him. Later, he repented of it. He gave a wonderful speech in 1946. At the time, he gave the Iron Curtain speech in Fulton, Missouri. He gave a speech at the University of Miami. That's where it was. And he says, "I want to say a word for the late learners." He said, "Maybe when you're of school age, you're not ready for that. And to take it up later is a great satisfaction."
- 2.60** And then he says, "What should the returning servicemen learn?" Back from the war, right? And he says, "The best things. Engines were made for men, not men for engines." We shouldn't train them purely vocational training. That's the same thing like he's saying with adult education. Then cancel culture. Winston Churchill was very hard to cancel. He made a form of that. Churchill made his living as an author. He was the highest-paid British author up to his time, excepting for George Bernard Shaw. It's what a man who wrote a book about it says. He did make quite a lot of money.
- 2.61** He had a gift for losing it. He reached the peak of his wealth in September 1929. And the British government fell in that month. And he had booked a lecture tour across America and back across Canada, and he paid a lot of money for it. And he just finished a big book. So he had quite a lot of money. And he arrived in New York and invested it all in the American stock market, and then went across the country and came back, and he'd lost quite a bit of it. But for Bernard Baruch, he would have lost all of it. Bernard Baruch was a famous man who did very well during the—investing, during the Great Depression. He was a shrewd cuss, and he saved part of Churchill's money.
- 2.62** But millions of people liked to read what he wrote, and he wrote it. And that's hard to cancel. Takes real despotism to do that, thoroughgoing despotism. In the 1936, 1937-38 period, the Conservative central office put pressure on publications not to publish Churchill's work, which cut off his livelihood. Then Churchill, in 1938, was at the point of resigning from Parliament because he lost a lot of money in two great American pullbacks, and he was about to lose his house. And he was saved by two Jewish men.
- 2.63** See, just remember, Hitler was a terrible tyranny. Well, he made a lot of enemies. And so a guy named Henry Strakosh, who was a German manufacturer, showed up and started giving Churchill information about German industry, what they were doing in it, weapons production stuff. Then in 1938, he bought Churchill's stock portfolio for what Churchill had paid for it. Eventually sold it back to him in 1952, which is how long it took for the recovery to happen.
- 2.64** And the other one, so he sort of saved Churchill's bacon. By the way, that transaction would be illegal today. We control rich people. We try to. We don't really. There's another guy named Emery Reves, and he was a Jewish man from Hungary, I think. He was a great entrepreneur, and he started marketing Churchill's writings all over the

world, a lot of famous ones in America. He helped save Churchill's bacon. It's very difficult to silence people, especially very talented people.

- 2.65** How have you personally changed as an individual through your time before Churchill? Was there impact in your life throughout learning about him and looking at yourself today? How have you grown as a person?
- 2.66** I'm bigger than I used to be. That's so wrapped up with my whole— I've led a life of thought and action. I've always been in charge for some reason. I never set out to be. I've actually never applied for a job in my life. I just got approached about things, and I decided to do them. That experience, being in charge of pretty big things, is good for a person, I think. It can be bad for you, too, I imagine, but you learn how to work with people, which is, make sure they want to do this. And then to the maximum extent possible, just let them do it. So I've gotten better at that, and I learned some of that from Churchill.
- 2.67** And then the most important thing to understand is beauty, in my opinion, the highest perfection of the highest things. Well, to understand that, you need examples of that in action, as well as art and thought and all that. It's been good for me to learn a lot about Churchill. Develops a practical sense because he just did a lot of things all the time, and he was good at doing them. But then also, he never thought—because it's very unique. Very unique is a stupid way to put it. It's almost unique that somebody wrote in such detail about what he did and did so much.
- 2.68** You know, experience teaches you patterns of things, and you can't predict the future. As I said, predictions are very difficult, especially about the future. But if you know what he did, then you can see it might work like this or it might work like that. So yeah, it's been helpful to me. Teachers should never give up.

Lecture 3: Churchill on Warfare

At a glance — Churchill on warfare and strategy.

- 3.1 We're going to talk about strategy today. Then tomorrow, we're going to talk more about the regime. It's a Latin word, French, modern, that is a different way of saying country. It's cognate with the word regimen, which is the way you live. And the regime is the way a people live. If there are people, they have some common way to live, something about them that makes them the same.
- 3.2 And so strategy, that comes from a Greek word. The Greek word for general is strategos. But what is strategy? The roots of it are in a big field. Strategy is a thing where—is stuff that takes place on a big field. It's big stuff. Tactics is different. It's close. Strategy is grand. When you say grand strategy, which is a common term, it's actually redundant, but emphasize this point, I guess.
- 3.3 When you think about a statesman, his work is the state. The Greek word is politikos, and the Greek word for city is polis. So, politics is what the polis does, and the politikos rules the city, but he has to know a lot to know it. He has to understand it. Ruling a thing doesn't mean—except in the case of tyranny, which is a very bad thing—it doesn't mean making it into whatever you want. It means understanding it.
- 3.4 And war, a characteristic phenomenon in all decent philosophy, beginning with the classics, is inferior to the life at home. It exists to preserve the life at home, but it's also dangerous. In the modern world, we can see it because, look at pictures of eastern Ukraine right now. But imagine that spread over all of Europe, and you've got a picture of Europe after the Second World War. You can find easily on the Internet a photograph of Tokyo in 1945, and what it was was a vast rubble.
- 3.5 So, war can overcome politics. It's supposed to be in service of politics, but it can destroy politics. And one of the things that the statesman would have to be concerned about was, would be, "How do you stop that from happening?" And to figure that out, you have to figure out a lot about your country. You have to figure out where it is, to start with, and where it is is very important.
- 3.6 I showed you this map up here yesterday. I'll show it bigger now. The little red dot. So, you can see the United States and the red around the United States is the part that Britain at one time or another held, including all of Canada and eastern United States. And this is sort of the British Empire at its peak. And the great white space up at the top to the right, that's Europe, Eurasia, and there's a little red dot off the coast. It matters very much that it's a little red dot, and it matters very much that it's off the coast, and it matters very much that it's near the coast.
- 3.7 If you take that same land and stick it out in the middle of the Pacific, you have the strategic importance of Fiji. It can be important, but commonly it's not. Whereas this is

27 miles, 29 miles, I forget, from the heart of population and power in the world. It's close, and yet it's divided. And that changes things. Island powers have a way about them. They tend to be naval powers. The seas around Britain are storming.

- 3.8** And I once lost a bet in Oxford. Somebody said, "No part of Britain is more than 50 miles from the sea." And I said, "Rubbish." And he said, "What part are you thinking of?" And I said, "Oxford," where we stood. And it turns out Oxford is the place in Britain that's farthest from the sea. It's 48 miles. And that means you get used to the sea. I'm not going to read it to you, but if you read the preface to volume one of Churchill's History of the English-Speaking Peoples, he talks about the fact that it's an island and how it changed the country.
- 3.9** First of all, think about that phrase, "English-speaking peoples." And aside—all I know how to do is asides—Churchill is a remarkable man. I mean, remember, I'm not prejudging the question, was he an evil or an unfortunate man? I'm just saying very remarkable man, because he worked out a lot of things that politicians don't normally do, like the strategic position of his country and how that relates to its politics and even gives rise to its politics.
- 3.10** Because the story he tells in the English-Speaking Peoples is, in the beginning, England was very open to invasion because you just had to go across some water. There were a lot of people who were good at that, and the British were not very good at that. They were more, what, primitive. They weren't as developed as they became. And the Vikings came, and then the Christians came, and the Angles came. It was a mixing pot. Eventually, the Romans came. That was very important in the history of Britain. They were there about 250 years, and they changed things when they were there.
- 3.11** But then Britain began to become more populous. Britain has been conquered twice from abroad, once by Julius Caesar and once by William I, William the Conqueror. He was a Norman. My wife's father's family is descended from the Normans. That means that they are conquerors of this place where they live and love. They've lived there ever since. They can trace it all back, and that's 1,000 years and more. And so those are the two conquests. But Rome fell and receded, and vestiges of it remain. Every city that's got C-E-S-T-E-R at the end is a Roman city. And you can find Roman walls in all of those cities. You can find Roman walls in Oxford.
- 3.12** William the Conqueror, basically, he was conquered back. There's a long period where the Normans are against the more native people who are themselves children of immigrants, for the most part Vikings, and they fight. The Robin Hood stories are from that time. But finally, it becomes a thing. William I, William the Conqueror, he ended up really ruling Britain. He was the ruler of Normandy, which is a big area in France. It's where the invasion that started, that we got back on the continent in the Second World War, was. But that became less important to him.

- 3.13** If you want to know the movements of British history, there's no better way to get them than to watch Shakespeare's history plays. You'll find that the history of Britain is a troubled history. Unusually successful, which means still it was Hades itself often. In the War of the Roses, that's the war between Lancaster, where my wife comes from, and York. Basically, everybody who was heir to a major title was killed. Basically, all of them. And it went on forever.
- 3.14** And the Hundred Years' War, which was the war between Britain and France, although they didn't call themselves Britain and France at the time, that was really over whether and how much of French territory the British would control. Churchill is very alive to this. He's on the side of Britain all the time. He was not on the side of Britain retaining major territory in France for reasons that I'll get to. It changed things that they are an island, close and separated.
- 3.15** If you watch the very great play or movie, Henry the Fifth, there's a recent one. They're all good. There's one by Lawrence Olivier, and there's one by Kenneth Branagh, and the latest one is Tom Hiddleston as Henry. And they're all great, but my favorite is Branagh. I watched that one in a theater in southern California with my mother-in-law, a great British lady. At the end of the play, the chorus says—you know, that's Derek Jacobi in this one. It's one guy, he's the chorus, and he narrates the beginning and the end.
- 3.16** He says that, after this glorious victory at Agincourt, which was one of the greatest military victories in history, within a few years, all of it was lost. Henry V, who was a great warrior, died young, and his successors were not very good, which is the problem with monarchy, certainly absolute monarchy. Britain was never an absolute monarchy, but the king was very powerful, well into the early 19th century.
- 3.17** When the chorus announced that, I heard my mother-in-law, a dear lady to me, groan to herself. Oh, her country got beat. Well, I had never groaned. I'm a partisan of Great Britain. The reason is, I knew this argument that I'm about to make to you. I knew that the Battle of Agincourt was really great. The British were expelled by Joan of Arc and by forces led by her, rallied by her. She's one of the most remarkable things that ever happened. Time spent reading about her is never ill-spent.
- 3.18** Who was she? She was this nobody. And she was a maid, the maid of Orléans. And she just became a military commander, and she always won. There are a few examples like that in history. And that's one reason why we think they're providential. It's so unlikely. Anyway, Churchill doesn't mind that Britain got expelled from the continent because it had effects in Britain and globally that he supported. And the key to the effect, in 1588, the Spanish Armada.
- 3.19** Now, France and Spain are the great powers in Europe. And because they're land-connected to each other and everybody else, they have to have really big armies. And now they do, succeeded eventually by the Germans, always had really big armies, and

they were really good. But a really big army and a really big navy is hard to keep together, to do both. Also, you need to be a seafaring people.

- 3.20** Have you read about the Athenians and the Spartans? That's a wonderful story. The Spartans were a slave society, and that made them very conservative. They didn't want to go far from home. Most of the work in Sparta, if you were a citizen, of which there were maybe 25 or 30,000, and there were a multiple of that of slaves, and if you were a citizen in Sparta, a male, when you were 12, you went to the "agoge," and for the rest of your—until you're 60, until you retire, you're a soldier, and you train all the time.
- 3.21** And the Spartans simply couldn't be beat for three or four hundred years. And when you fought them, they were practiced. It was like a military parade coming at you, and it was fearsome. The spears would all come down at the same time, and they were in perfect cadence. It's just death coming at you. And it basically always was, forever. But the cost of that was that the work at home was done by slaves, and that made them weak. They couldn't go.
- 3.22** Every nation has a strategic position that makes it both weak and strong, and to preserve the nation, it's not just winning your wars. Wars are going to happen. It's, how do you win your wars in a way so you remain what you are? The Spartans—when the Greeks joined together and they fought the Persians, vastly outnumbered at land and sea, and they beat them twice, big. Now, Greece is great. Of course, what happens is, the Spartans and the Athenians get into a rivalry. Began to fear each other.
- 3.23** Thucydides, who wrote the story of that—the first real history book ever written is Herodotus, the story of the Persian Wars. It's great reading. The Battle of Thermopylae, you know about that. "Go tell the Spartans, stranger passing by, that here in obedience to their laws, we lie." The Spartans who were killed to a person, they put that on a wall, and they won at Thermopylae because they cost the Persians a lot, and they gave the Greeks the idea that they could win this war.
- 3.24** Well, that's over now, and now they're fighting each other. And Thucydides' judgment, he was an Athenian, a partisan of the Spartans, his judgment was the war was caused by the "phobos," the fear. The Spartans feared the Athenians. Thucydides makes a—not Thucydides, Pericles makes a famous speech, the Funeral Oration. Some people are killed and the war is starting up, and he makes a very patriotic speech. It's very worth reading.
- 3.25** And one of the things he says is, "We can't be beaten. We've got this navy; we can go all over the world. We have our walls." The Piraeus is the seaport still for Athens. If you go to Athens on a ship, you'll stop in the Piraeus. Then Athens is 15 or 20 miles up the way. And so they built high walls that whole distance so they could communicate with the port. And that meant a land army couldn't take them. They converted themselves into purely a naval power. Well, they had a very strong army, too, but not like the Spartans.

- 3.26** And so that was hubris, right? You'll never find in the works of Winston Churchill, "We can never lose this war." What he always says is a famous thing he said in 1940, "And if we are expelled from our island, the new world will come to the rescue of the old." And that means Britain is a kind of an idea. It can go all over the place. It's actually a reminiscence of the Jews who were the first ancient people who didn't disband when their city was destroyed. In the ancient world, until the Jews, the gods were principally local gods, and the Jews are a mixture. Their God is their God, and he gives them laws.
- 3.27** Turns out to be a very hard duty to be the chosen people. They're always falling short and getting punished. The story of the Bible, looked at from the perspective of the New Testament, is that drama is a demonstration for all the world of God's providence on Earth. And come try to get picked for a duty like that, it'll be hard on you. But the covenant with Abraham is, "I will be your God and you will be my people, and this will be a blessing to all the peoples on the face of the Earth." You see, it's a grand providential thing.
- 3.28** There's lots of talk like that in the history of the United States, too. That means that there's some principle that's our principle, and it covers all people. Hitler didn't have that. Well, he did. "The good of all people is to serve us, the superior people." And come to find out, that's a hard argument to make. The others are not likely to believe it. Hitler had lots of enemies. The Soviet Union is different. They have a class argument that applies universally. That means that if you're in the wrong class, you'd better fear.
- 3.29** How a nation is formed, what it's formed for, affects it powerfully, as does its geography. And so in 1588, what happened was, the British proved that they were getting really good at the sea. And they lived right next to it all the time. And trade is growing, and that's how it works. And once you can conquer the seas around Britain, the North Sea and the Channel, which are very stormy, you can go anywhere, fast. You can carry heavy goods about the Earth, faster on the sea than any other way and cheaper.
- 3.30** Even today with air power. Somebody told me, I know a man who arranged the logistics for the first Gulf War, and he said that if we had moved everything by plane, it would have taken 10 years because planes can't carry much. Ships can carry a lot. And so it took four months. So think what happens because of the English Channel. You don't need a big land army, and therefore, it's hard to get one. Because people respond to an emergency. If the enemy is coming over the border, they'll volunteer and they'll get behind it and they'll join the army, sustain the army. It's very expensive to sustain the army.
- 3.31** If the king doesn't have that, it makes him weaker. Navies are not very good for oppressing people at home. They're over there on the water. There are not that many of them, by the way, and they're not good at land fighting. If you become a naval power, two things happen. One is you're open to the world, and the other is the executive, whoever it is, does not have a big force to come and make the people

behave. In the story of the British Constitution, which is, they say it's an unwritten constitution. What it is, in fact, is a series of big documents, most of them negotiated with the king at a moment of crisis.

- 3.32** The crisis is always the same. The king wants to do X, and the Parliament wants to do Y, and the king tries to make them. If he's got a lot of force, he could make them. But in the English Civil War, the worst and bloodiest of the contest between the King and the Parliament, the one where Charles I got killed—they chopped his head off; Oliver Cromwell did that—Parliament was able to raise an army to beat the King's army in about three years, and they beat him by a lot. And that's because there wasn't a big standing army.
- 3.33** At the same time, France had become a great nation state, centralized. And Louis XIV had armies, big armies. And so if you're the Huguenot or somebody who's a dissenter, you'll find that there's a lot of troops to deal with you. And so the Parliament grows, and it becomes powerful. And Parliament comes from the Latin word *parler*, the French word. It's speaking, right? Government by talking. Churchill loved that phrase.
- 3.34** Now, I have to zoom back to Aristotle for a minute. In Book 1, Chapter 2 of Aristotle's *Politics*, he says, "Animals then use their voices to indicate pleasure and pain. But we use ours to distinguish the just from the unjust." The justice of the treatment of a thing depends on what kind of thing it is. But speech depends on that, too. Because make me a sentence without a common noun. Smartest always use a sentence and the imperative word, "Go." That's a sentence. But it doesn't work, because to know what go is, you have to know what going is. There are many ways of going.
- 3.35** Somehow, we can recognize them all, and those are common nouns. And so that just opens up a world. And since we use our voices to distinguish the just from the unjust, he says that we are closer than horses and bees, because we can talk. You see, and that means whatever we can think, we can say, and whatever we can say, we can think. And that means we can open our souls in a different way than any creatures. And so, the implication is, you bind together around a common idea. The first paragraph of the *Politics* says, "Every community is formed for some good."
- 3.36** Can you name the one for the United States of America? "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal." That's America. That was the reason it was done. And everybody today, we have huge disagreements about what that means. But you can see that they're serious disagreements because that's what they're about. They're about the formative thing. So when Churchill uses the expression "English-speaking people," he's talking in a classical language.
- 3.37** And that means that this little thing up in the corner there has got a principle that can go anywhere, and it's got ships to go on, and it goes. It's interesting. The British Empire was not formed according to a plan. Churchill says it was founded mostly in "a fit of absence of mind." Explorers wanted to go. It was somewhat like this in some instances,

but in Spain, they knew there was gold somewhere, and they sent a bunch of men, priests, and soldiers to go get it.

- 3.38** And a society made up entirely of men is very unstable. Why? Because they're boys. They're no good. They're useless. Just deal with kids on a college campus. Boys are actually flightier. That's a really terrible thing to say, but it turns out it's true. Boys are more easily distracted. They did found one colony in—the English did, Roanoke, just men. They built a stockade and they put up a sign and said, "We're going off to explore." And they were never heard from again. Don't know what happened to them, right? A bunch of boys wandered off in the wilderness. If they had families, they'd be rooted.
- 3.39** They called the British settlements plantations. And see, Britain becomes this little cauldron. It's safe, relatively speaking, and it doesn't have a despotic army to run the whole place, and people get to live, and they thrive when they get to live, and they make more then. Then there's not jobs for them. So they end up going all over the place. They start trading. That's very economically efficient. That really works, because some places in the world are good at one thing, other places in the world are good at another thing, each does what they're good at, and they trade. It's efficient. It works.
- 3.40** They become this great nation, and they become this democratic nation. Let's say the rule of law, which means nobody gets to overcome that, try though they might, and the kings do try, and the Parliament tries sometimes, too. But there are checks in place and balances of power that stop it from getting out of hand. And so, this little country comes to be the most powerful country in the world for a long time. These are the reasons.
- 3.41** Churchill believes that these things make it a great country, too. He loves to say that the heart of Britain is in two places. It's in a little citizen in a private booth, saying how things are going to be. Nobody else there. That's the first place. And the second place is the Chamber of the House of Commons. Churchill thought that was a magical place. I started thinking about architecture for the first time because, in the Second World War, they bombed out the Houses of Parliament.
- 3.42** And so now they're going to rebuild them, and they're making plans. And the House of Commons will only seat about two-thirds of its members. And that means, when everybody's there, it's standing room only. And they were going to make it bigger. Churchill gave one of the most important speeches of his life. It's called A Sense of Crowd and Urgency. He says that, just like the location and shape and surroundings of the island have a huge impact on the British people, the House of Commons has a huge impact on the way of governing Britain.
- 3.43** And he says, "Just think. It's not a semicircle." And that means it doesn't move progressively from red to pink to blue. Shades, many shades, right. There are two sides. When you walk in, you bow to the Speaker, and you turn left, and you join the

government, or you turn right, and you join the opposition. There's not a third direction. You've got to make up your mind. Then the other thing is, they're facing each other, and they're close to each other. The acoustics are really good, which means they can also shout you down. And you're arguing right at them.

- 3.44 The benches, they go up on risers. And the backbenchers, they're the ones not sitting on the front row, and the ones sitting on the front row are the important ones. And so you walk in and there's this scene in front of you every day, and it shapes the pattern of politics. Still today, very much. I mean, they're in a mess over there right now, which is not atypical. Churchill loved to say, "We will not repeat the mistakes of the past. We will make new mistakes." That's what they're doing right now. That's what we do all the time, too. It emphasizes, it's called Parliament. It's a place to talk. We're going to be governed by what we say.
- 3.45 A famous thing, never to be repeated, is that Charles I invaded the House of Commons with some soldiers. Cromwell later did that, too, by the way, but he got away with it. It's fun to go, by the way. You should go and see where they—because you can see, geography matters, architecture matters, location matters. And so it's good to go and look. You got to go to Athens, you got to go up on the Acropolis, see what that place is.
- 3.46 You got to go to Rome and you got to walk the Forum, which at one end is the Colosseum and the other end is a more modern thing, but three-quarters of the way toward this more modern thing up on the hill is the Forum. It still stands. That's where the Senate met. And that's where they killed Julius Caesar. And you can walk the steps that the assassins took to retreat and make sure they weren't overwhelmed. And that's where the great Civil War started that destroyed the Roman Republic. But it all happened right there.
- 3.47 And the way it happened was shaped, in fact, by the way of the things right there. It was the governing center of the entire world. One of the first things you notice is, it's not very big. It's not as big as governing London, not as big as governing Washington, but it was big enough. So you go into this place and you're going to talk. That's going to be very consequential. It matters what you say now. And yet speech doesn't kill anybody. And speech can be responded to. Speech doesn't cost a lot of money. You don't have to tax people to death, but an army, you do.
- 3.48 And so government, by talking, that is the use of the rational faculty. In Greek, when Aristotle says, "Animals use their voices to indicate pleasure and pain," when he talks about the human voice, the word is *logos*, which means both reason and speech. They're the same thing, and so, to be governed by that, and that requires a whole bunch of conditions. So poor little Ukraine, it's just badly located. I mean, maybe it's going to be saved, maybe not. I would guess that parts of it will not be saved. But that's because there's somebody really big and close who wants it, and it's hard to stop them. If Ukraine were an island, that would not be true. They get an advantage.

- 3.49** I think of us as an island. Churchill did, too, because we're a very big island. In one way, we're the biggest island. But on the other hand, 15% of the world's population is connected by land to our island, and 85% of the world's population is not. And that's power. That's how that works, right? So I think, I don't think, my personal opinion, it hasn't been good for us to think we're such a big deal because we've become profligate.
- 3.50** Now, that's—Winston Churchill understood all that. I know it from him, and I know it from classical and political philosophy and from history, but he figured all that out. And remember, he didn't go to college. It was probably good for him that he didn't go. But he studied a lot, and he learned a lot, and he was observant. Now, you can see, because of these arrangements, including where the country is and what's near it and the way the country is governed, including in what buildings it is governed. The house is a Parliament.
- 3.51** They actually belong to the Queen, and they're rented for £1 a year from the Queen by the Parliament. But the Parliament has been in there for 600 years, round numbers, that place. And that's very important. One of the things you learn is, if you build things—I've been privileged to build a bunch of buildings at Hillsdale College. I didn't build them, but I was in charge of the effort to build them—is that you learn to shape them for what they're for.
- 3.52** Here's a little trick. I learned this from Churchill. This is a big room with high ceilings. If we were going to have a meeting with 10 of us, somebody sitting at the front and others talking back, it would look like nobody came. If you're going to have a meeting with 10, get a room for 10. But if, on the other hand, you're going to have dinner, imagine the biggest salon in the palace of Versailles. Wouldn't it be cool to walk into that salon and walk 40 yards to the table in the center, and you're going to sit around with 10 people and have dinner. And you look at that and you go, "Wow, all this is for us." Psychologically, they're opposite phenomena.
- 3.53** Things like that matter a great deal. If you're interested in politics and interested in being an active citizen, you have to think about things like that, because people are persuaded or not by everything they hear and everything they see. To attend to that when you're organizing things is a good idea. We built some beautiful classroom buildings at Hillsdale College. The original building is pre-Civil War and had a big part in the Civil War, important building.
- 3.54** But then we built a bunch of modern buildings, and alas, we built them in the '60s and '70s, and they've got flat roofs and they're big, they're red brick buildings. And darn if they didn't build the insides out of red brick. And the windows are like turrets. I think I know why that is. I think the architect wanted to show us a movie when you walk by the building or by a window. You can just see it unfolds. I've been destroying those buildings, and they're almost all gone now. And now the classrooms have light and high ceilings, and it looks like a place where you're about to do something important.

- 3.55** We are physical beings, and we are of a certain size, and we notice things like that. Things like that affect our politics. Winston Churchill was a remarkable man. He understood that. If you get a form of government like the one Britain has and the one we have, it's really good at getting everybody involved. Everybody gets a chance. People speak their minds incessantly. It's maddening, right? That gets people committed. They like it.
- 3.56** Churchill writes, I have to paraphrase, he writes— in 1901, he was elected to Parliament in 1900, and he was pretty fresh, two years from the Battle of Omdurman. He'd seen that terrible thing that he saw. He saw a bunch of brave people mowed down without a chance. He saw the people who killed them not in much danger. He just did not think that was good. Never did come to think that was good. What to do about it is a very different question, because you're going to fight somebody with machine guns with your spears? It won't last very long. But it's a sorry development.
- 3.57** And so, he comes back, and it's 1901, and he's a young conservative. He makes his first big speech. It's called Army Reform. And he was 27, when he made this speech. We should take most of the readings from the Churchill class and post them somewhere where these people can see them. You can read them, if you're interested. And, of course, you can get the books, too. There's a man named Juan. Is the other guy named Juan, too? This is Juan Davalos. I think he's going to be emperor of Latin America. These things are really great to read.
- 3.58** Churchill, as I told you, he wrote so very much, and almost nobody is ever able to read it all. And I have. And it was a dumb undertaking. But once you're in it, you can't stop. And so I picked out bits. That's what teachers do. Then you can find out yourself more. And there's endless amount. I have probably read every word that Winston Churchill wrote, but I'm not sure, because 40 years of doing it, more than 40 years now. And once in a while, I discover something that I didn't remember. And does that mean I didn't read it before? I don't remember. And often it's something beautiful, too.
- 3.59** So he goes to the Parliament, and there's a plan. The British are fresh from the Boer War, which was not understood to be a smashing victory. Cost a lot, a peace that didn't give them everything they were after. The racial problems in South Africa were not cured. What the British did was they kept authority over the tribal lands. They didn't give that to the Boer government. They didn't trust them with it. They thought the British would do better. It's an open question whether they did do better or not, but many British at least had an intention to do better. But still, it was a sore and it went on forever. Still goes on.
- 3.60** Now the British, they won the war, more or less. They're rich and important, and dangers are growing, especially Germany on the continent. And so they have a plan to double the size of the British Army. Churchill is hot against that. And the speech he makes is a microcosm of everything he thought about strategy. And many speeches that he makes are like that. You can zoom ahead to 1946 to one of his most famous

speeches, the Iron Curtain speech. He called it the Sinews of Peace. All the same arguments are in there, too. Different situation, different light cast on them. You can learn more by reading them all.

- 3.61** But he's thinking the same way for a long time. And what's he thinking? His first job, he thought the first job of every British subject, was to preserve the integrity of those two little places I talked about. The ballot box, the ballot booth, and the House of Commons. And so everything has to be done to preserve that. And that means you can't turn the society into a militaristic society. You can't spend all its money on common projects.
- 3.62** One of his favorite sayings from the—there's a great 19th-century liberal saying. Churchill was a liberal for part of his career. "Money should fructify in the pockets of the people." Because why? Because then they can do stuff. They can think. You have to find a way to preserve your country that doesn't cost much. That's hard. "Got a lot of money, spend it. We'll be great." He didn't think like that. He believed that it would be the death of the country if it became, well, we'll get into that next time, but if it becomes socialized. And it did become socialized.
- 3.63** You could say of Winston Churchill that he set out early in his life, foreseeing and seeking to prevent the great wars. You could say that he set out early in his life because he just said these things often, trying to prevent socialism from coming to Britain. He was 0 for 2. Life is like that. As the Rolling Stones say, "You can't always get what you want. But if you try, sometimes you get what you need." This 1901 speech, Army Reform speech, it's called, he says that we're underestimating what's going to happen here.
- 3.64** He said, "The wars of the future will be different from the wars of the past. The exhaustion of the victors will be matched, of the vanquished will be matched by that of the victors. Every resource will be poured into the war." Of course, that means there won't be any resources left not poured into the war. He predicts that in 1901, and he says, "Don't build these army corps because they're either too much or not enough." He also says a theme that receded in prominence, but he never took it back, that democratic countries are very fierce in war, and they can get carried away because everybody's involved.
- 3.65** And that means, by the way, I think it would be shameful for one not to support his country if it was in any way a good country. I think ours is really good, but in a mess. But on the other hand, you have to think. And war fever gets to running. It's running right now about the Ukraine. Are you a good guy? Do you support Ukraine? It's like, you're not a patriot if you don't. I'm like everybody else. I support it within some very strict limits. So it—you have to think about the nature of regime and then add in this factor.

- 3.66** It's true, in the ancient world, that wars could simply overcome cities. The last time it happened, Alexander the Great conquered Thebes and stole the women and children into slavery and killed all the men. That was mean and decisive. And that happened more than once. That was the last time it happened. Why did he do it? His father, Philip of Macedon, died. There was a rebellion up in the north. He went up there to quell it, and the Thebans rebelled in the south, and he just came down there and killed them all. No more Thebes.
- 3.67** Thebes was the conqueror of Sparta. They're the first ones to do that. Really amazing place. No more. They're all gone. And that can happen there. But in between that time, when war could be total, when everybody could be killed, there was a long time when that wasn't the case. I mean, war has been hell, especially for ordinary people, all along. But there was a long time when war was fought by aristocrats, mostly. And that means not so many. I talked about the War of the Roses. The House of York and the House of Lancaster just basically killed each other off. I mean, the big families and their direct heirs.
- 3.68** But now you've got—Churchill writes once, "The war"—it's about the First World War. "The war through which we have just passed differs from all modern wars in the consequences for the population. It differs from all ancient wars in the thoroughness of the destruction." That's a bad development. Churchill saw that development. Before the First World War broke out, he spent months shuttling back and forth to Berlin, trying to stop it from happening. Why did it happen? A lot of reasons.
- 3.69** At the time, when that's going on, all the monarchs are related to each other. The Kaiser of Germany and the Tsar of Russia were nephews of Queen Victoria. If she wrote them a letter, she called them Willy and Nicky. Why are we going to visit unexampled destruction on Europe, fighting each other, when we agree about so much? But that's what they did. Again, in the Second World War, and worse, and Churchill saw both of those things coming, and he hated them and tried to prevent them.
- 3.70** Now, in the First World War—and Churchill was a show pony. He was 26 when he was elected to Parliament. By the time he was 36, he was a senior minister and famous. I talked about turning points. A big one came in 1911. He saw that briefing I told you about, with the railways going toward Belgium, and he thought, "Wow, look what they're doing, preparing to do it. Really?" Then he was at a party on Park Lane, which is next to Hyde Park. Nice place. Somebody mentioned that there was a naval ammunition store in Hyde Park. The building is still there. It was unguarded, and this is very like him. He left the party and went to his office and got on the phone and had soldiers guarding it by midnight, and they stayed there ever after.
- 3.71** But at the time, he was very wrapped up in domestic policy, and he switches this emphasis. Now there's an emergency, and it's the emergency that made him do it. He always thought, in his life, he always gravitated back toward peace, toward great things

to do in peace, to make Britain better and keep it free and keep it more comfortable. As I say, he was one of the inventors of the social safety net. But also he was good at war.

3.72 In the First World War, he was not Prime Minister when either of the wars broke out. He was First Lord of the Admiralty when the First World War broke out. And the Admiralty, the Navy, is a great thing. That's the prime warfare ministry. He became the First Lord of the Admiralty, as it's called, in 1911. And when the war broke out, the fleet was ready. But they never found a way to make it decisive in the ways it had been with the Napoleonic Wars.

3.73 And so what the First World War turned into was trenches, and Britain lost 950,000 killed. We lost North and South, about 700,000 killed in the Civil War. That's our worst. Britain lost 375,000, Second World War, I think. We lost about that number. 900,000 is a lot. And of course, the wounded would have been a multiple of that. So they got hurt very bad. My wife's grandfather was in all three battles of Ypres on the Somme. There were days where they lost 10,000 people.

3.74 You're going to live in these trenches in squalor for months, and then you're going to go over the top sometime, or they're going to come at you. You can go, if you want to see a place—it's hard to find a place that's permanently scarred by battle. The First World War was over in 1918, so that's more than 100 years. Verdun still looks like a battlefield. The pitholes from the shells are everywhere. They preserved some of it, too, because until the Battle of Stalingrad, that's the most costly battle in human history. There's a little film you can watch about it in the museum there. I think you can find it on the internet, too.

3.75 How did the war work? Well, it was an artillery, barbed-wire, machine-gun, trench war. They would charge across open ground, littered with barbed wire and stuff, and they'd be mowed down. But that's a lot of heavy stuff, steel, in tonnage. How did—both countries built railways to Verdun, to carry stuff there, people and goods and weapons and ammunition, to be expended there. Most of it never left. They ate it up. They just chewed each other up for months and months. Nobody liked that. That was the worst. Verdun was the most intense.

3.76 But the battles of the Somme, farther north, they were terrible. I'm told—Penny didn't really know her grandfather very well—I'm told that he was shattered by the experience. Never the same man after. Her family are lawyers. It's a law firm. Part of it is still alive. It was founded in the year of the American Revolution, and these three families ran it until Penny's daddy retired. But the regiments were territorial in those days, and that meant that if some regiment had a bad war, everybody that you knew of age was in it.

3.77 Penny's daddy was a camp commander of a Japanese POW camp for three and a half years. And he was not scarred by it. He was a tremendous man, and he was funny and self-effacing. And he was a lawyer. He was a grand figure at a certain level. There's

lords up there, too, and they're grander. And he was not really rich. And the guy who started Reebok lives up there, so he's like the rich guy. But they were people of service for 250 years. And the service cost them a lot. It changed them. It didn't change my wife's daddy all that much.

- 3.78** Well, the first time I went to meet him, he was a big figure in my mind, and of course, I'm going to try to get hold of his girl. And they're foreigners. How am I going to deal with that? On the way up there, Penny said, "Daddy doesn't like to talk about the war. He didn't talk about the war much." So I say, "OK, I won't talk about the war." I go in, and it's 8:30 at night, and he says, "Would you like a drink, young man?" I said, "Thank you." And he said, "What do you do?" And I said, "Well, I work for Martin Gilbert." He said, "What do you do for Martin Gilbert?" And I said, "Well, I do research."
- 3.79** And he said, "Into what?" And I said, "Well, the life of Winston Churchill." He said, "Of course. What part?" I said, "Well, right now we're working on the Second World War." He said, "What part?" I said, "This week, and for the last month or so, Dunkirk Beach." He said, "I was there." He left Dunkirk Beach the last day anybody did. We talked till 11 o'clock at night about that. He didn't like to talk—he loved to talk about the war. He just didn't like to talk about himself. If you knew something about the war, just really great.
- 3.80** Anyway, I learned so much from him and think, that's a kind of life. Compared that to the Spartan life. If you're a citizen, you're a soldier all your life. If you're not a citizen, you're a slave. What about feats of bravery and service from people who are ordinary lawyers in a provincial town? Who can produce that? That's a very remarkable thing. That means, by the way, that nations that distribute power around, they are powerful. They can do a lot.
- 3.81** Right now, military recruiting is down a lot, dangerously. Worst since we went to all volunteer. Well, I have opinions about why that is, but I also believe that I know what will turn it around. If we're attacked, I think there are reservoirs in a country like ours, and they're deep. It looks very bad. Looks very bad to me right now, but on the other hand, the strength of the nation is very mighty and probably not over. You learn that talking to—Dennis Houghton was his name. Really great man.
- 3.82** Now, you see, it's a great patriotic cause, if you go to—at Oxford College, I was in Worcester College, and in every Oxford College, there's a list of the dead from the First World War and the Second World War. The one from the First World War is much longer. These are people who are privileged of the society, and they were wiped out. Lots of them. Not as bad as Thebes. So, Churchill is a minister in all of this, and he hates this kind of warfare. He hates it with all his heart. And he argues against it like crazy. And he starts thinking of things to do. And he thought of two big ones.
- 3.83** Neither succeeded in the Second World War, but they both changed the world. The first one was, he got a naval engineer to start doing designs for a vehicle that could

cross the trenches and was armored, and he thought that up. The code name for it was water-ships tanks. Churchill started the experiments that produced the tank. That's because he doesn't want all those people killed on either side, but especially the British side.

- 3.84** Here's a quote from—now, I'm going to tell you the thing he did that led to his worst disgrace of his life in a minute. He's like me. He's like any of us, probably. When you do something disgraceful, then you write a whole lot to explain it. I'll get to that. I'll read that quote in a minute. There was a big tank battle, one, in the First World War, and the British tanks did break through marvelously, and they took a bunch of ground and took almost no casualties. Then they were in the rear, and they had no idea what to do. They got surrounded and cut off and all that.
- 3.85** But that, by the way, that gave rise to the people who studied that the most and the best, that battle and how to do that right. Their names are Rommel and Guderian and Patton and de Gaulle. By the time the Second World War came, they were ready. In the Second World War—in the First World War, the Germans did this great sweep up and far toward the sea, to the West and the North, through Belgium, which didn't do anything to the Germans, to get to France.
- 3.86** And they flanked them, which was their plan, the Schlieffen plan, it was called, by a man named von Schlieffen who made the plan, 20 years earlier, by the way. And they completely disorganized the British and French lines. There's a couple of really great books you can read. There's a man named Edward Louis Spears, and he was a friend of Winston Churchill, and he was raised a lot in France, and he spoke beautiful French. He was the person assigned as a liaison officer between the British and the French armies in 1914 and again in 1940. And his books are just awesome to read because he understood.
- 3.87** And of course, when two armies from two different nations come together, there's a fissure point there. And maybe you can break them up. And what they did when the retreat started, because everything was thrown into disorder, when they showed up in such numbers and so far from where they were expected. And so the British—and order breaks down. And it's interesting what happened. It's by osmosis.
- 3.88** In the First World War, they managed to hold it together. But the impulse of the French army was to head for Paris, and the impulse of the British army was to head for the sea. And that's what happened in 1940. The British—and nobody ever really gave any orders about that. They didn't know where anybody was. It's all busted up. What they did in the Second World War, and this was an act of imagination by Hitler, who did have some imagination. They were going to do that again with variations.
- 3.89** He said, "Yeah, they'll be expecting that, won't they?" So these two young officers, Rommel and Guderian, they made another plan, and the plan was to go through the Ardennes forest with tanks, and it's just tracks in the mountains. Nobody thought they

could do it. And they went and walked it, and they decided they could. So if you picture in your mind the relative positions of France and Germany and the North Sea and the English Channel, the French had built between the wars the Maginot Line, which is heavy entrenchments, and then they were going to funnel them to Belgium and defend them in Belgium.

- 3.90** But the Ardennes forest is down south and east of the Maginot Line, and they just think they can't get through there. And they do. And one of the reasons they were confident, thought the roads were impassable, but they're confident they couldn't do it, is they'll never carry enough fuel. They forgot that France, by this time, was littered with big gasoline stations. The Germans didn't even pay. And they show up in the rear of everybody, and they cut their communications, and it's just complete disorder. The British, as they say, start gravitating toward the sea, and the French toward Paris. The British got away, and that was a miracle.
- 3.91** Churchill sees these trenches going on, and he hates them. He served in them for a few months, too, when he was disgraced. He thinks up a grand plan. If there's trench lines that go from the Alps to the sea, you still have to go around somehow, because to go through is very costly in the thing that you value the most, the lives of your citizens. So how do you go around? Well, you have to go around Europe. And so he thought of two ways.
- 3.92** The one he favored, and there's only two ways to go, north or south. I guess you could go west and go around North America, but where would you show up? Russia. So, yeah, you can go north or south. And both north and south go through chokepoints, by the way. North to the Baltic, and there's an island called Borkum, and they wanted to take it, and then they wanted to build up a whole bunch of troops over there and then invade from there into Germany and make the German lines recoil. Something's in their rear now. That's the one Winston Churchill favored.
- 3.93** The other way was to go through the Mediterranean and up through Turkey and the Black Sea. If you read the articles about what's going on in Ukraine, a lot of them are about that. The thought was, we can force the straits of the Dardanelles with ships. There's a man named Jackie Fisher, who was one of the great innovators of the British Navy. He invented the dreadnoughts, which are all big gun ships. And see, these technological things, they change a lot. Britain had the biggest and by far the most successful navy in the world.
- 3.94** And the trouble was, now they're building these all big-guns ships, and a ship that's got a mixture of guns can't stand up against one of them. And so Jackie Fisher, at the peak of its glory and fame and power, introduced the dreadnought into the British Navy, which means they made the greatest navy in the world obsolete. But that's imaginative and necessary. And then he's an old man, and he's a very difficult man. It turned out he was a traitorous man, too. Churchill brings him back at age 80 to help him with the navy. Churchill loved him.

- 3.95** So Jackie Fisher is the one who favored through the Dardanelles. They take that one, and it doesn't go very well. They lose some ships. Turkish mines are a problem. They lose some minesweepers. They put one of their best ships down there. That was Jackie Fisher's idea, the Queen Elizabeth II first. And so they're going to abandon the effort. Churchill went to Prime Minister Herbert Asquith, who had a problem with drinking, especially in the evening, and said, "You've got to order them to go again tomorrow. They refused my order," and Asquith refused. And a few days later, the government fell.
- 3.96** Jackie Fisher disappeared. It was found out, they looked for him for several days. He was hanging out in the Charing Cross hotel with his mistress, corresponding with the opposition. And Churchill fell, and the Dardanelles was a failure. Now, it's a longer story than that. Eventually, they sent some troops to take the Gallipoli Peninsula. And the effect of that, the result was, they just reproduced trench warfare now 1,500 miles away.
- 3.97** And what Churchill thought was they didn't move fast enough. And there's this, there's a photograph in the Churchill biography. A retired general was brought out to command the troops that go to Gallipoli. And there's a photograph taken from up on the heights, looking down on the bay where they stopped. And the British soldiers are bathing, sunbathing on the beach and diving off the ships into the sea, while they send scouts up above to see what's up there.
- 3.98** And the scouts come back down and say, "You got to get up there. If they occupy this, we'll never take it." And the guy said, "Well, we'll go tomorrow." Well, who arrived at the top, marching for 36 hours without stopping, was a force under Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, who became the founder of modern Turkey. And they never did take the Dardanelles, and they lost 30,000 men trying. And so that was a massive failure, and Churchill was blamed for it.
- 3.99** He learned something from that because other people who'd been endorsing this plan and shaping the plan, when there was trouble, they would back off, and Churchill wouldn't. He became the advocate for continuing the thing, and he took the blame. There was a commission of inquiry after the war. It exonerated him. But never mind; it takes time for that to get fixed.
- 3.100** And so his reaction to that. First of all, he was miserable. It's a low point in his life. He's out of office. They make him—I can't remember, I think he was Chancellor of the Duchy of Lancaster, which is an honorific. It means you get to sit in the cabinet meetings, but you don't have anything to do. And Churchill always thought, "It's better to have a job than to just be around and give advice." Because if you've got the navy, you can invent the tank if you want to. But if all you can do is sit in the room and give advice, it's useless.

- 3.101** He alienated a lot of people. He said one day, "Every day, a thousand to 10,000 young men are killed in this war. We sit here and talk about the cause. They know the cause. What they need from us is a plan. What is our plan?" Well, ministers hated him for that. So he went and fought in the trenches for a few months. The soldiers he commanded at first hated him, but then they found out they really liked him.
- 3.102** The first thing he did was he bought a big old huge bathtub. He loved to take a bath, twice a day, sometimes. He played with a rubber ducky in the bath. But everybody had to take a bath. He had water being heated and all that. He got rid of the lice. Operation Delouse was his first big military operation as a regimental commander. Then the other thing, I only know two people in that terrible war about whom there are stories of them having a somewhat playful attitude about it. One of them was Douglas MacArthur, who would charge and carry a cane and wear a white sash scar through all that hell, never wounded.
- 3.103** The other was Churchill. And they would go out and explore between the trenches, crawl around, listen, look, try not to make any noise. One thing is recorded. He says, "Turn off that bloody torch." It's a flashlight, right? Then this little voice comes in, "It's yours, sir." He was good at war. Danger lifted his spirits. Then he comes back and he never did get the trench warfare stopped. The way the war ended is the German army mutinied. And that's the story of that war, by the way. Whoever is on the offensive is drained.
- 3.104** And the Germans, they had the advantage of the aggressor, they took a lot of territory before the trenches were dug, and then they defended. But then when Russia collapsed and became the Soviet Union, they got to transfer 2 million troops to the West, and they went on the offensive. They got to the outskirts of Paris and the army mutinied. There's a lot of good poetry about that, because this war was miserable for both sides. The Second World War was bigger and more costly, but it wasn't as uniformly all the time miserable for everybody who fought it the way the First World War was.
- 3.105** Don't get me wrong. There probably never was a worse place to be on Earth than Stalingrad or Okinawa. Very heavy casualties, living in squalid conditions. The point is, you have to stop that if you're going to keep a free country. You can't just go bleed for years. That's not how you do it. If you do it, you won't be a free country.
- 3.106** In 1936—Hitler is looming now—and he wrote an essay called What Good's a Constitution? It's one of my favorites. It's published in Britain and America. It makes mention of the fact that—he never makes a criticism of Franklin Roosevelt by name—that Franklin Roosevelt has declared a war on poverty. If we're always going to be at war against domestic opponents, too, what room will there be for us to live as free people?

Lecture 4: Churchill on Leadership

At a glance — Churchill on leadership.

- 4.1 I have two questions for you. They're related to your lecture in a more general sense. First is how do you redefine a just war? Then secondly, how do you reconcile the glorification of the virtues of war despite the horror of its casualties?
- 4.2 Well, justice just means don't take anybody else's stuff. In the end, that's what it means. There are things that belong to you, your natural property. They start with your body. They extend to the things you produce. And so you may not take those things. And if you do, that's unjust. Every unjust war, for example, the Russian attacks on Ukraine are, obviously, unjust. But is that enough to know that we have to do something about it? You have to think more.
- 4.3 It's complicated because you're certainly not going to rectify every injustice in the world. You got to pick somehow. How do you pick? That takes a lot of thinking. So, yeah, justice is, don't take anybody else's stuff. And of course, it's more than that. I mean, you pay what you owe. In my line of work, what I'm supposed to do is help young people grow. That's the heart of it.
- 4.4 And so I'm obliged. I took the job. I have to try to do a good job with that. And I mustn't let other things get in the way. To the best of my lights, that's what I try to do. Well, it'd be wrong if I didn't do that. I didn't have to take the job. I could quit today if I want to. Some days I do want to, but not today. So, yeah, that's a just or an unjust war. What was the other question?
- 4.5 It was, how do you reconcile the glorification of the virtues of war despite horror of its casualties?
- 4.6 Well, the virtues of war are not particular to war. What is the prime virtue of war? Courage. Is courage a bad thing? My philosopher friend Jack Handey says, "OK, if you mean by a coward, sniveling and worming and crawling, then OK, Mr. Brave Man, I guess I'm a coward." Nobody wants to be a coward, right? And the fact that that can lead to bad things, not as bad as cowardice. The governing virtue about whether a war is advisable or not is not courage. You just need that to fight it. It's prudence, practical judgment. Do you think it's bad for people to be young and healthy and strong because they can use that to beat somebody up?
- 4.7 Yeah. You mentioned yesterday that Churchill was very much in favor of Britain's government, and particularly the idea of bringing the ideals of Britain to other parts of the world through, let's say, imperialism. What did he think about the United States and our Constitution, and why would he not approve of our Constitution as better than Britain's?

- 4.8 Well, as a young man, it's a little ambiguous, which he thought was best. But as a young man, in his first speech in Parliament, he comes back from the Boer War, a war hero, and he uses this phrase. "If I were a Boer, fighting in the field, and if I were a Boer, I should be fighting in the field." That means he's not condemning the enemy. And so he gets a lot of crap about that. And he writes back, and it's just wonderful what he writes. He says, yeah, he says. "The claims of country are real claims and have to be respected unless the claims made are extreme." And in this case, I don't think they are for the Boers, right?
- 4.9 What did he think about America? He thought it was the hope of the world. He thought that— Churchill was an unusual man for so many reasons. And one was he had this vast experience, had a good mind to think through what it meant, too. And so he could just add up the weights of things. How are we going to beat Russia in Ukraine? That's a practical question. If you think about it hard enough, you'll see that that won't be easy. And so he was good at things like that.
- 4.10 So, you got Nazi Germany coming after you, and their army has a couple hundred divisions and your army has six. How are you going to beat them? Well, the plan was together with the French and other European armies. But in the space of about six weeks, all that disappeared. Now, where are you going to go? So he thought that's the place. But he also, from the first time he went to the United States, he just loved the place. And that's unusual because Churchill was a great patriot.
- 4.11 And the phenomenon was becoming mature now that the United States was becoming a more powerful country. And British people didn't like that. I wouldn't like it. He didn't mind. He thought, "Yeah, they're just us with some happy refinements." He loved the Declaration of Independence. He talked about it all the time. If you read Churchill, watch for this. It's not easy to write a paragraph that's beautiful about what your country is about. Churchill could do that. Maybe I can find it. Excuse me while I do some research.
- 4.12 "The Earth is a generous mother. She will provide in plentiful abundance food for all her children if they will but cultivate her soil in justice and in peace." You see what that means, by the way? That means we don't have to kill each other to eat. That means that it isn't a zero-sum game. And that means that conflict is not the natural way of things. You see, it's peace. Peace is better. The speech is set up, it's 1946. Churchill is the greatest man in the world, and he's lost his job, which is a happy thing, because Harry Truman wanted to reverse American foreign policy, not fully reverse, but alter it significantly, so that we were going to confront and contain the Soviet Union.
- 4.13 And so how is he going to do that? And he asked Winston Churchill to come and give a speech. And the speech is really cool. Churchill went to Fulton, Missouri, on a train with Harry Truman from Washington. And they talked for 24 hours. And he cables to London that he's read him the speech and Truman really liked it. But Truman denied that. Churchill is a private citizen. He's not Prime Minister of Great Britain. He showed it to

the Cabinet back home, but he's just speaking for himself, and he's got the standing to do it.

- 4.14 And the speech begins with, "I'm in a private station. There is nothing here but what you see." I have a photograph of him saying that, of the peak. And what you see is Winston Churchill at a podium, and right over here, sitting down, is Harry Truman. And then he says, the way the speech goes is, "What's the danger of the world?" There are two things, marauders, he calls them, war and tyranny. And, "Now, I come to the second danger of these two marauders, which threaten the cottage home and the ordinary people."
- 4.15 Churchill always thought about that, see. Namely, tyranny. "We cannot be blind to the fact that the liberties enjoyed by individual citizens throughout the British Empire are not valid in a considerable number of countries, some of which are very powerful. In these states, control is enforced upon the common people by various kinds of all-embracing police governments to a degree which is overwhelming and contrary to every principle of democracy."
- 4.16 "The power of the state is exercised without restraint, either by dictators or by compact oligarchies operating through a privileged party and a political police. It is not our duty at this time, when difficulties are so numerous, to interfere forcibly in the internal affairs of countries which we have not conquered in war." You see, this speech is about peace.
- 4.17 "But we must never cease to proclaim in fearless tones the great principles of freedom and the rights of man, which are the joint inheritance of the English-speaking world, and which, through the Magna Carta, the Bill of Rights, the Habeus Corpus, trial by jury, the English Common Law, find their most famous expression in the American Declaration of Independence."
- 4.18 Now, he gave a Fourth of July speech in 1918, toward the end of the First World War. He does it all through his life. The first time he did it was there. He turns the Declaration of Independence into a source of unity between Britain and the United States, whereas its immediate effect was actually opposite that. He's very artful about that.
- 4.19 But he uses that language to say something that every serious person believes, and that is, human beings are things that carry the motive and movement of themselves inside themselves, and they have a right to guide themselves in moving. And anything else is a violation of human nature. It's one reason why I object so strenuously, and to my great cost, to this system of indoctrination from central places that they have put in place over education. I mean, with explicit purposes now, to present facts, "facts", to students, to shape what they think. You see? The facts are bad enough without distorting them.

- 4.20 Anyway, one of the things I admire the most about Winston Churchill is that he could, in a few words and often, and remarkably, similarly, over his long career, state what the principles of freedom are and why they're a blessing. He was a politicos. He understood about the polity. He understood how it works. He understood what it takes to preserve it. Churchill was a great—we'll talk about domestic policy in our next thing. But you'll see there, too, he was a great peacemaker.
- 4.21 He was looking for a way for it to be fair for everybody. He doesn't agree with many things we think today. A lot of our politics today are built on the idea that resources are unlimited, and they're not. They're produced by people, and people have the right to produce them. And if you take too much from the people who produce them, they won't produce as much. And those are just laws. Those are how things are, right?
- 4.22 And if you accommodate yourself to that, there is an act of surrender in that. It means you don't think you can perfect the world. And if you can cross that divide, then you can come up with some great policies to make things better, in my opinion. Yes?
- 4.23 Would you say that Winston Churchill had a particular style or signature to his speeches or any underlying messages or themes that he would repeat throughout the course of his career?
- 4.24 Oh, yeah. The first thing we have that he wrote that might be for publication— it wasn't published, it's just in his files—it's called The Scaffolding of Rhetoric, and it's a summary of Aristotle's Rhetoric, more or less. And it's got a bunch of rules in it. It's very good reading. "Use old words, simple words. Speak in the declarative voice. Accumulate arguments." A lot of things like that. Then about writing. And see, he dictated his writing, and he dictated his speeches. It was the same thing. And he got really good at that, in my opinion.
- 4.25 And so, he gives a lot of advice, especially to young people, about how to write. His very great friend, Lord Birkenhead, F. E. Smith, who was a heck of a guy, great lawyer, jurist, Tory politician. And Churchill was close to him when Churchill was a liberal and when he was a conservative. And so Freddie Birkenhead, Lord Birkenhead's son, is going to write a biography of his father. And he says, "How do I write a biography?" And he says, "Well, they begin at birth." It's like that.
- 4.26 But no, his advice about writing is that he started learning about how to write when he learned what the components of writing are. And that starts with words. Use the right one. And then sentences. And that's a thing. A sentence is a thing. And it can't be anything. It's got to be a thing. And then paragraphs, that's very important. And so paragraphs announced themselves. That's why you have topic sentences. But you can vary that. A parallel structure matters a lot.
- 4.27 Because why? What makes writing easy to understand? It announces itself all the time. The title tells you the first thing you need to know. The first sentence of every paragraph tells you what the paragraph is about. The sentences are crisp, and they

follow in an order that makes it available to the understanding. And that's why parallel structure is about this. If you read Macaulay, it's a very florid writer, right, very complicated writer. And yet you see that the parallel structure is exquisite. And I can't, I don't have a passage memorized, so I'll make one up that's like him.

- 4.28 "The Welsh who are given to faction and whose families are tight would do X." So that's complicated, right? A bunch of subordinate clauses. "And then the Scots," and then just have the same structure of subordinate clauses, whatever they say. And you've already been over it once. Now you can follow it. And the whole thing is to tempt the reader on. Then I told you about that paragraph because Churchill said and wrote a lot of things about this. And that means that, if he violates the rules in a paragraph, you go, "Ah, what's he up to?"
- 4.29 That paragraph that I talked about in *Painting as a Pastime*, I think he's being shy. I think he doesn't want to claim competence. I think the whole tone of the essay is, "This is a hobby; this is light and fun." And so he doesn't just start preaching at you. He fools you. And I think it's exquisite. I think it's very beautiful. And I've never read anybody—never met anybody who read that essay and didn't love it. And that's because—and just think.
- 4.30 So Aristotle defines rhetoric in one way that deludes a lot of people, but the big way is, it clears that up. He says that the purpose of rhetoric is persuasion. Say anything that will persuade them. But of course, if you persuade people of something that's soft, false, the evidence will accumulate that it's not true. So what, his actual splendid definition is, "Rhetoric is a truth-disclosing, active condition of public address." So it's showing the truth to people in public address. And that has limits. It's not geometry class. Proofs in geometry are proofs. In rhetoric, it's working off things that people already believe, and comparing them and extending them.
- 4.31 And you never come away—like, the most difficult, is it true? Probably the most difficult, most consequential decision Churchill ever made in his life, he made on May the 28th, 1940. Before I get there, let me tell you one thing so that we can understand what the devil I'm talking about. If it's true that war is terribly dangerous and getting more dangerous all the time, and made more dangerous in particular by the unity and the productiveness, especially of free countries, how are you going to control that? That's a problem of statesmanship.
- 4.32 Here's one of the places we described it, when he talks about, he writes a six-volume work to vindicate his wish to go to the Dardanelles or around the trenches because he's very thorough. This is the general being a statesman. In this passage in the *World Crisis*, it's in volume 2, he's explaining why the generals in the First World War were deficient.
- 4.33 "Wars are won by slaughter and maneuver. The greater the general, the more he contributes in maneuver, the less he demands in slaughter. The theory which has exalted the 'battle of wearing down' into a foremost position is contradicted by history

and would be repulsed by the greatest captains of the past." By the way, Churchill's ancestor, the Duke of Marlborough, he fought one battle that was just a slugfest, and the casualties are very high. And Churchill makes the point that Marlborough repented of that battle for the rest of his life because that's not how you do it. Because there's all these dead people now. Is that good?

- 4.34 "Nearly all the battles which are regarded as masterpieces of the military art, from which have been derived the foundation of states and the fame of commanders, have been battles of maneuver, in which very often the enemy has found himself defeated by some novel expedient or device, some queer, swift, unexpected thrust or strategy. In many such battles, the losses of the victors have been small. There is required for the composition of a great commander not only massive common sense and reasoning power, not only imagination, but also an element of legerdemain, an original and sinister touch."
- 4.35 Isn't that cool? Then this sentence, which is a great sentence to memorize and understand that it's one of the axioms of the study and practice of politics. "The distinction between politics and strategy diminishes," some is left out here, "diminishes as the point of view is raised. At the summit, true politics and strategy are one." What does that mean? That means you have to fight your wars in a way that strengthen your country, that exacerbate its strengths and minimize its weaknesses. Yeah.
- 4.36 In a way, is that almost juxtaposed against real politic, like total war, consideration of the political good in peacetime during war? Or is it the same thing?
- 4.37 It is the same thing. You see, we talked about practical judgment. We should do a course on Aristotle. You guys want to study Aristotle? Because if you don't, you're fools. Practical judgment is a very interesting thing, and it's not rules. I am anti-rule. I don't like rules. I have repealed 130 or 40 pages of rules at Hillsdale College because nobody can remember them. I've got the student rules down to 17 rules, not pages of rules. I'm trying to get it down to 10. And every year we look at them and say, "Can we get rid of this one?"
- 4.38 And the reason is, there's only one rule that works, that everybody can remember. Be good. If I ever have to discipline a student, which is rare, I will ask them what they did, and they always tell me, and you know, hang face, and I say, "Was that a good thing to do?" And if it wasn't, they say no. Then I say, "Don't do that anymore." And it's over, right? If they do it again, that'd be different, but they don't.
- 4.39 The boy who dropped an ice cream cone on my table at lunch from the floor above. I knew they were doing that, and I thought it was funny until they did it to me. Then what did I learn when they did it to me? I learned that it's disruptive, and I learned that the staff doesn't like it because they got to clean it up. And so I put out my secret net. I said, "I need to know the name of those boys." And they said, "How do you know it was boys?" And I said, "Really?" And they—about a week, takes about a week. It's like

throwing a bottle up the river, comes back down. It takes about a week, and three boys show up in my office wearing suits to apologize.

- 4.40 What they're secretly hoping, and these boys all got that, is they get to stand up at commencement and be named the dumbest boys in the college. But anyway, what does that prove? We actually all know the good. We do. And so that is the rule you need. And then work it out after that, because prudence—see, that's my point—there's no rules about prudence. It's never always right to do X or Y. It's always right to do the right thing. And that changes a lot.
- 4.41 You mustn't kill anybody. Would you kill Hitler if you got a chance? You know? Circumstances matter a lot and decisively. And then you have to get that straight in your mind because also, however, what Aristotle says practical judgment finds is the truth in each situation. Once you account for the circumstances, there's one right thing to do, even if you can only guess what it is, because sometimes it's very unclear. And so the point is, do you do total war? The answer is maybe. What you do is the most expeditious thing to restore and preserve the peace. Maybe.
- 4.42 I mean, you can think of circumstances where you wouldn't do that. I can. And that would be very sinister if you could figure out a way—I think China is dangerous. I don't think we're nearly smart enough to provoke them into a conflict disadvantageous to them. But it's a tempting idea, isn't it? If you do something like that, you always got to remember, by the way, that whatever you do is going to get found out. You might as well just tell everybody right now. It's my practice. That's why I cause continual outrages. Yeah.
- 4.43 What would you say was Winston Churchill's leadership philosophy?
- 4.44 Philosophy. Easy to lead and hard to drive. Do the good. But how do you lead people? First of all, they need to follow. If you make them follow, it'll be a pain. Just think, say, we're going to walk down the road together and I'm going to show the way, right? Well, if people are always wandering off, it won't be any good. But if you have to constantly be watching them to make them go the right way, that too won't be any good. So it's just—we are not herds. We are closer than herds because each one of us can carry the direction in his own soul. That's unity. But you got to get that, and the way to get them is to ask them.
- 4.45 You mentioned that Churchill believed that Britain was an idea. Like he said, if you were exposed to this island, the new world will come to rescue the old. How would you summarize, and how would Churchill summarize, the British spirit? What is it, and how is it unique from, let's say, the American spirit?
- 4.46 That's a very good question. Big question, too. Of course, he never laid that out. The reason is, a sharp answer to that question would make a difference between us, and he didn't want that. Now, by the way, I just put myself in a place of having to prove a negative, and you'd have to read three million words to prove it. We have everything

Winston Churchill ever wrote, searchable. But how would you search for that? So it's hard to prove, but I submit that it's so, to the best of my knowledge.

- 4.47 He talks about differences. The British Constitution is more flexible. That has advantages. The American Constitution is more fixed. That has advantages. He talks about both sets of advantages and disadvantages in the same essay. I've already mentioned it. What Good's a Constitution? Our Constitution is not simply fixed, by the way—in my opinion, these days, not sufficiently fixed. So they've got that. And then you have to remember, Britain has a queen and an aristocracy, and they've democratized that very greatly. I fear my wife has turned me into a monarchist.
- 4.48 I grew up in Pocahontas, Arkansas. I think all that's funny by nature. But this queen is something else. And Winston Churchill adored her when she was a little girl, and was Prime Minister when she was coronated, crowned. And she's a woman of great duty and grace. And think what her life is like, right? She can't— in one way, she's terribly powerful. The business of the government cannot proceed without her. She has to sign stuff all the time. She has a weekly meeting with the Prime Minister. She keeps up. Lord, she's 90-some. So it's a life, and it's a hard life, in luxury.
- 4.49 And that institution, you see—a constitution is a form, right? And forms are ways that represent the essence of things, but also they describe how they proceed, right? So where do you see America? Well, everywhere you go. But no, you can tell what part of America is acting for the whole on the nightly newscast because they got cameras set up outside the Congress and the White House and the Supreme Court. At the moment, when those things act, they are supreme. They take turns. That's why there had to be three places.
- 4.50 In Britain, they just sit outside Downing Street, right? And they don't have separation of powers, except that Churchill believed that they did. I'll tell you how later if you want me to. So it's a form, right? And the monarchy is a form, and the aristocracy is a form. Churchill very much wanted to take advantage of the forms, and that meant that he had this plan for reform of the British Constitution. It's more or less the same plan for about 30 years, and it's another of the long list of things that he never got done.
- 4.51 The way it would work is, Churchill was at the point of his fear when the power of the House of Lords to overturn an act of Parliament was compromised decisively. He was a liberal at the time. They proposed a social reform budget. The House of Lords kept striking it down, and he got the Parliament Act. He was one of the leaders in the debate on the Parliament Act, and it reduced the power of the House of Lords to do that. Now they can only delay.
- 4.52 Well, he said at the time, and he repeated for the rest of his life, "We have to make the House of Lords stronger, not weaker. It just can't be stronger on a hereditary basis." And so his basic plan for that was to have the House of Commons appoint a group from various groups. So first of all, some percentage of the hereditary peers would still get to

be members of it, and they'd rotate. And then local grandees and generals and distinguished citizens would be on the list, and the House of Commons would pick. In other words, he was building a Senate after the Roman fashion, after the American fashion.

- 4.53** And he thought you needed that. It's a form. But then the form, and that means that it takes some of the advantages of aristocracy and it incorporates them into the British Constitution without the hereditary part. That's because sovereignty has to come from somewhere. And it can come from your daddy and your mommy, or it can come from the governed. It can come from the Pope, it could come from a lot of places, it can come from, but you've got to pick a way. And so this is popular sovereignty. Free governments are governed by the consent of the governed.
- 4.54** So, how do you take that principle and then take advantage of the aristocratic heritage of Britain to build up authority that's not just all the authorities in one place? And so he thought about things like that a lot. And today, the most intelligent commentators to my eye, there are a couple of scholars who write very well about this. The government of Britain is like the government of the United States. It mostly happens in the bureaucracy now. And the popular front face of the government is less powerful than it used to be.
- 4.55** It's not true that the government is being governed from that little chamber. It could never be governed in detail from that little chamber. Churchill didn't want it to be governed in detail. He wanted us to do it. My plan for the schools is to let the teachers and the parents run the schools. They're the ones who know and love the kids. They'll say, "OK, yeah," but they get all this support, all this great academic expertise. Who am I to argue against that? Except I do all the time.
- 4.56** Because first of all, it's not rocket science in school until it becomes rocket science, and that's later. What it's about in the beginning, and for a long time, is reading, writing, and arithmetic. Everybody can do that. Everybody, if they try hard enough, can teach it. That's why millions of people successfully homeschool their kids. You don't need all that. It'd just be better if it weren't there, because all that is also one of the strongest political forces in the land.
- 4.57** And so, where is the sovereignty? Ask yourself the question: By what principle does the administrative state claim its authority? The answer is murky. When it's a public debate, they always claim they're empowered by the political forces. They are. Congress has delegated its legislative power to a bureaucracy, which, if the Constitution is clear about anything, it's clear that that's not to be. But that's not the real point, because if they try to withdraw it, there'll be a scream. And then the argument will be, "No, we're the experts. We're the ones who can work out the details."
- 4.58** You see, and there's no alternative to us because the popular branches could never do that. And the point is, what about the people? Can they do it? The answer is: sure, they

can. You people are nuts. You travel many great distances to come and study a bunch of stuff that happened a long time ago, and it's complicated. Why are you doing that? Well, it's a beautiful thing to do. You want to do it. And you can do it because you want to.

- 4.59** It's very hard to get into Hillsdale College. What does it take? Same thing every human endeavor takes. It takes willingness and ability. And I try to make sure that we do not fail to emphasize willingness. If somebody is applying to Hillsdale College, they say, "How can I get in?" And I always say, "Argue your way in. Go tell them you won't be denied. Tell them, I'm going to do this. Don't get in my way." And we love arguments like that. We're going, "OK, all right. This is stupid, but try. You might flunk." They never do.
- 4.60** One of my greatest colleagues in my entire life is a man named Servini, who works at the college. He's the longest-serving employee of the college. The day I came to work, he wanted me to be the president of the college. He said, "You have to take this job." And I said, "Probably will." And he said, "I'm not the smartest guy in the world, but I'm loyal and nobody ever outworked me." That's 95% of the battle. And my reply was, "I hear you're pretty smart. And about the outwork thing, we'll see about that." Because you can do a lot if you just intend to outwork everybody you know. And find a way to be happy doing it, because you can't sustain it unless you do.
- 4.61** So, yeah, that's about aristocracy. I read this quote about, how do you solve the problem of war? The answer is: it takes judgment. It takes insight. It takes imagination. It takes excellence. You don't always have that, and you can't institutionalize that. Plato's Republic, "The cities will be miserable until the philosophers are kings, and they won't be." Because why would they? They have better things to do. And the rest of us can't make them because we don't even know who they are.
- 4.62** But nature is not entirely perverse. Often, when we've needed them, we've produced real excellence in authority. I mean, I don't know if you know much about Abraham Lincoln, but go learn. Here's another thing. On the 28th of May 1940— I was about to tell you this story. I'll tell it now. Here's this man, and he spent his whole life, from 1898 on the field at Omdurman until 1940, trying to avoid the cost of war, getting ready for the two world wars, trying to be prepared, thinking being prepared is the way to prevent them, trying to make a deal when they break out.
- 4.63** In 1945, they're planning the invasion. Harry Truman and Winston Churchill are planning the invasion of Japan. The estimate is a million dead people from that invasion. Churchill says, "Maybe we should do something that could appease the Japanese national honor to prevent all those deaths." Harry Truman said, "The bombers of Pearl Harbor have no national honor." Churchill said, "Maybe, but they have something they call that, and maybe it's more important to them than it is to us." So in other words, don't suffer unduly.

- 4.64 But on the 28th of May 1940, that's the one time in his life, I know, where he didn't do that. He's the Prime Minister. He's been Prime Minister since the 10th of May. The war cabinet is Neville Chamberlain, Edward Halifax, the two makers of appeasement. In Churchill's eyes, Chamberlain actually vindicated himself through these days. Then there was Churchill, and then there was two guys from the Labor Party, which didn't have any votes in the Parliament at that time. And so the power is still with the Conservative Party, and the Conservative Party still favors Chamberlain and Halifax.
- 4.65 Churchill had not yet become the greatest man in the world. That happened over the course of 1940. And it's funny. Do I say that as an objective fact? I think it, but you don't have to know that. What you have to know is that everybody treated him that way. He still had enemies, but now they were treating him like he's the greatest man in the world. Joe Stalin treated him like that. Franklin Roosevelt treated him like that. Look what he did. Wow. Anyway, he's not that now.
- 4.66 And so they're going to have a peace proposal from Mussolini, whose nephew—am I getting it right?—was the ambassador in London or the foreign minister, I forget. And he's in touch with Edward Halifax, one of the great appeasers, and the rival to be Prime Minister when Neville Chamberlain resigned. Churchill got it. Churchill mostly got it because he's very forthright. This all happened on the 9th and 10th of May. The government's in trouble because the war is not going right and Hitler is beginning his attack on France. Nobody knows that France will be gone in six weeks. Nobody can even really quite imagine that.
- 4.67 But there's a very rough debate, and it falls to Churchill to defend the government. He does it by taking responsibility for all the disasters, some of which were under his charge—an attempted evasion of Norway, for example, which went wrong. Everything went wrong for a long time. He's a very good debater, and it's a very ironic position. One diarist, member of Parliament who wrote about the debate, what he saw in the debate, said that he thought Churchill immensely enjoyed the irony of the situation, because if Chamberlain resigned, Churchill would probably get his job. But he didn't stab him in the back. He fought for him, effectively.
- 4.68 Then there's a man named Kingsley Wood, and he was in the cabinet; he was a Chamberlain guy. And he was one of those guys, he was a lawyer from the north of England, I think. Chamberlain, he's one of those guys that the Prime Minister plucked out of nowhere and gave him a seat in Parliament, gave him a Conservative seat to run for, and then put him in the cabinet. And he's the one who called Churchill the night before. And he knew what the plan was for the meeting on the 10th of May.
- 4.69 Kingsley Wood said, "Chamberlain is going to offer to resign. He's going to say, 'It's got to be one of you two.' For once in your life, wait him out. Don't say anything. Let Halifax talk first." Churchill records that it seemed longer than the moment of silence observed on Remembrance Day, sitting there for a minute. And then Halifax said something very like Halifax. He said, "Well, I think it would be hard for me to manage the government

in wartime from the House of Lords." Now, a resolute man might have said, "I'll leave the House of Lords. Give up my title." But he didn't say that.

- 4.70 And so he got all that out, and Churchill said, "I will form a government by nightfall." So he's ready to go. Remember what I told you about how to get into Hillsdale College. That's the way. Now it's 18 days later, and the whole world has fallen apart. And Halifax, the foreign minister and the cabinet jobs in Britain are not like here. They get those jobs because they have standing in the Parliament, and the Prime Minister can't fire them and unfire them at will. His government might fall. I mean, they have just been doing that over in Britain. It's just a godawful mess. Who's going to be able to keep it together? Maybe nobody.
- 4.71 Over here, the President lets the Secretary of Labor go. Does anybody know who the Secretary of Labor is? I don't. Once in a while, I'll get the fond hope that there isn't one, but there seems to be. Halifax is bringing this news, and it starts on the 23rd of May. It's a really good book by John Lukacs called *Five Days in London*, and it tells this story step-by-step. It's also in the much bigger official biography. He says it's got this thing here, an appeal. Maybe we should talk to them.
- 4.72 Now, through all these five days of conversations, Churchill knows that if Halifax and Chamberlain quit, his government will probably fall, because they're a pair and they're popular. Churchill gave on the 10th of May—on the 12th of May, after the weekend, he gives the "Blood, toil, tears, and sweat" speech. Do you know that speech? When he becomes Prime Minister, he gives a speech that's this long. It's very bracing.
- 4.73 "You will ask, what is our policy? It is to wage war, to wage war by land, sea, and air. To wage war against the most monstrous tyranny," something, something. "You will ask, what is our aim? It is victory, victory at all costs." See, at all costs. A man extremely reluctant to say that. "Victory in spite of all terror." This is a really bracing speech. So he gives the speech, and then the world goes to pot, starting right in the hour in which he becomes Prime Minister. And so now he's got this thing going on, that they want to talk.
- 4.74 And it proves, although he just said, "OK, find out what they're offering." And it comes up day after day, and it sharpens, and Churchill is delayed. We don't fully know why he was delayed. In the end, we know that he had a very strong conviction about it. But it's possible he thought—see, Martin Gilbert, Sir Martin Gilbert, the great historian, kick me right now for saying that. He hates the use of word perhaps or possibly. If you ever wrote a memo and you put "perhaps" in something, he would just circle it and put "perhaps not."
- 4.75 In the writing of 19th- and 20th-century history, there is no room for the word perhaps. That's what he'd say. It's a terrible burden to carry that advice because you got to look things up all the time. Anyway, perhaps he thought the war effort would collapse if it was announced that there was going to be a peace negotiation. Because we do know

he resisted it really hard. And so on the fifth day, May the 28th, it's become sharp enough now. We have the cabinet minutes to know what people said, that Chamberlain might—not Chamberlain, Chamberlain was good. Halifax might quit.

- 4.76 And Churchill does a maneuver. He calls the whole cabinet together. He sent his private secretaries around, chased around Whitehall, finding them, getting them in the cabinet room in 10 Downing Street. He just gives them a talk. There's no writing. Almost everything Churchill said in his life is written out in advance. Here we have the notes, especially by a cabinet, a very left-wing Labor minister named Hugh Dalton, who happened to just love Winston Churchill and agree with him about next to nothing. And he makes a very close transcript of what Churchill says.
- 4.77 And Churchill talked for an hour without any notes, and he describes the war situation. If they invade, the first towns they take have names that are repeated in towns in New England, in America. And maybe they will come to help us. And then the culmination of it, and he says, "We have a navy, and it will come down to a big air battle," which it did. "And we will have some advantages in the battle because we'll be over our home turf, and that changes how long the planes can stay in the air. And that multiplies the number of planes you've got because they've got a lot more."
- 4.78 Then he says this thing I have memorized. "I've been thinking in the last few days whether it is part of my duty to open negotiations with That Man." He didn't like to call him Hitler. He was going with That Man or That Bad Man. Once in a while, he called him Little Corporal Hitler, and sometimes he called him Little Corporal Schicklgruber. Because there was a nasty rumor going around that he was a Jew, and that would be the best insult you could give him. That Man.
- 4.79 "And I believe that every one of you would rise up and tear me down from my place if, for a moment, I were to consider parley or surrender. If this island's story is to end at last, let it end when each of us in this room lies choking in his own blood upon the ground." Now, that's a cabinet speech. He records, and others record, that he finished that and there was silence for a minute, and then everybody leaped up and rushed him and beat him on the back and cheered.
- 4.80 Then he turned to Halifax and Chamberlain and said, "Maybe we have our answer." The next thing Halifax said was, "I'm afraid if we open negotiation, we'd be on a slippery slope." Just think about that. There's very few people who would have even tried to do that. And the chief rival for the job that he got certainly would not have. And that resolution changed everything.
- 4.81 Now, did it change everything for the better? Hard to say. Britain was not as great a country anymore after that war. They spent what they had. And he's responsible for that. And he knew that. And he's the one who gave the warnings for so long. "Fight to the death, you'll be dead." And so he made a judgment, which he expressed in many speeches, "Better to die than be associated with these people."

- 4.82 Sir Martin Gilbert was a great historian of the Holocaust, too. Penny and I worked with him on books about that. One of the things that struck me the most was transportation orders signed by French officials to put Jews on trains to go to the east, to the factories that were built for killing and incinerating. That never happened before. And that means that they're complicit in that. And did they have a choice? Their families might be shot, would be, in many cases. But the point is, that's a miserable place to get. There are no good options. And maybe death is a better option. Yeah.
- 4.83 In Churchill's writings, did he ever comment on any enemy tactics or strategies that he respected or objectively thought were brilliant?
- 4.84 Oh, yeah. He had great admiration for Rommel. Rommel participated in a plot to kill Hitler. Many of the best officers did. When Rommel died— later it was discovered he was executed—Churchill talked about what a great soldier he was. I argue—I can show you many instances—Churchill was not a vindictive man. He was very quick to forgive. I mean, he was a killer, make no mistake. But he didn't like it. He liked the fight. He did like that.
- 4.85 Who else did he admire? He wrote essays. There's a little book—you get it cheap and you can get it on Kindle— Great Contemporaries. There's an essay about Hitler. It's reserved, let's say. That's before the war, before Hitler became the ogre that he was, although he predicted that he had to choose not to do that. He could see that he might. Yeah, he wrote—and he wants to get along. He thinks Germany is a great thing. It has to be restored. He's for that faster than anybody.
- 4.86 So what are the themes of the Second World War—his history of the Second World War — "In war, resolution; in defeat, defiance; in victory, magnanimity," and I'm forgetting one. Does anybody know what the other one is? You're all as ignorant as I am. So, in other words, just remember, peace is better than war. The key to peace is justice. The key to justice is to let people keep their stuff.
- 4.87 You're young. What's the most important stuff to you? Your capacities and your chance to develop them. That's what you need. That's what you want. That's why you're here. That's an investment in the one thing certainly under your charge. So keep making that investment. You have a right to.

Lecture 5: Churchill on Politics

At a glance — Churchill on politics and regime.

- 5.1 OK, we're going to try to connect some things today. I've used the word regime. Serious statesmen, and even most non-serious statesmen, have some idea of that. What kind of life should we live? What country should we have? And those are points about the end of things. What's the right thing for us to do? And then you also have to have opinions about how. It takes what you might call final causes and formal causes, ways of proceeding.
- 5.2 And so it's unambiguous about Churchill, what he thought were the final causes. Effectively, he was an American. What I mean is, he conscripted the Declaration of Independence into being a British document, a continuation of the great British documents, the Petition of Right and the English Bill of Rights and things like that. That's controversial because it's an aristocracy. They still have titles in England. They're still inherited titles. They haven't made any new ones for a very long time. But there are lots of—
- 5.3 I mean, you watch Wimbledon, a bunch of titled people come out on the court to give the awards. Who are those people? This time, this year, somebody married into the royal family. There's that, and that's manners and habits changed by that. You have their forms of address. My wife told me once she went with her daddy somewhere when she was a girl, and they were going to meet a bishop. The House of Lords is the Lords' spiritual and temporal. And the Lords' spiritual is the senior clergy, the bishops and archbishops. And the temporal is that's in time, and that's dukes and earls.
- 5.4 "How shall I address him?" And her daddy said, "Well, just mumble 'my lord' once, and then you don't have to keep doing that." Those forms, people act that way. They have ways of behaving. In America, not that. We have a power structure today, and always have had. My fear is that the one that we're having is becoming ossified and unrepresentative, but that's aside. The point is, there's going to be one, everywhere. It affects the manners and the way people talk, and it affects the way they think about what's right.
- 5.5 So now, Churchill was a monarchist all his life. He believed in it very much. Reign, but not rule. And that was an arrangement that was worked out over three, 400 years and involved a big high body count. But now it's settled, right? In this world today, nothing is settled, what's going to happen after Elizabeth II. But he very much wanted the monarchy to be there and to do what it does. And it has formal parts in the making of British law.
- 5.6 When Parliament opens, there's a route that the Queen takes. And the gate at the right end, the House of Lords end of the Palace of Westminster, and she goes in that gate and she gets out and she goes into a throne room, her room. And she greets a few

people and she sits a minute. And then she goes into the House of Lords and she reads something written for her by the government of the day about what they're going to do.

- 5.7** I once said to Martin Gilbert, "That changes things, doesn't it?" Because you couldn't really put in her mouth the words, "We monarchists are a bunch of despots and we should all be killed." Some people say that in Britain. And Martin Gilbert—he was the Churchill biographer, in case you don't know who he was—he looked at me and said, "Don't sell them short." And she would have to read it, but she has to read it, or he, if she has a male successor. And that's a form, right?
- 5.8** How can you have the whole basis of the political system be the equality of rights? The answer is the forms of British government, and they're not like ours. Ours have evolved. If by evolved, you mean change, ours have changed a very great deal. But they were designed at the beginning. They were written in the summer of 17, what, 87. Took about three months. They came out with a plan, and the plan was pretty much adopted intact. It hasn't been changed very much.
- 5.9** You can read—it's a very rich record, including the notes of two of the people who were in the convention about what everybody said. And then the gloss on it, or the argument for it, that those who made the Constitution made for it in the ratification. So it's like that. The British Constitution happened over hundreds of years. You have to think and read carefully to find the theme in it. But there is a theme in it, in my opinion, and Churchill very much argued for this theme, that Britain was broadening its base steadily without abandoning constitutional government.
- 5.10** To him, constitutional government meant strength and restraint in the government together. Got to be strong, got to keep order, got to keep the law, got to fight us wars, and win them. But it's got to be restrained. It's got to let people alone to the maximum extent possible. He loved the phrase—it's a phrase from English history, and I can't remember right now who said it: "Leave to live by no man's leave beneath the law." So you can do what you want to, as long as it doesn't violate the law, and the law doesn't dictate everything. Indeed, as little as possible. He was a liberal in that sense.
- 5.11** Now, that's all one thing to say, but how do you keep that in being? Oh, before I go into that, remind me of when I'll go to that. There's a big problem with this account of Churchill. Churchill was an imperialist, and that means governing some people without their consent. Why is that right? And he wrote and talked about that all his life. It wasn't much of a problem in his lifetime because all of the important colonies, which means the great majority of the people who lived in the empire, were self-governing. They passed their own laws, they declared their own wars.
- 5.12** I said last time that they did mainly in Australia, New Zealand, Canada, South Africa. I'll forget one. They just have an amazing record sending people to Europe to fight in European wars on the side of Britain, and they didn't have to. In 1942, it became plain

that—'43, really. They were fighting in North Africa. The United States had come in, the Soviet Union had come in, and they had overwhelming force. It looked like they were going to win the war. And getting ready to go fight in Europe now, having won in North Africa.

5.13 And the Prime Minister of New Zealand, Peter Fraser, wrote Churchill a letter. And he said, "We only have four divisions, and the best one is there with you, and we have the Japanese out here. We want to bring them home." And Churchill wrote him a letter and said, "I pray you don't do that. I pray that you realize that the main battles are here, that you can hold off the Japanese, that when we win here, then we won for the world, although we got to go fight out there. I hope they will stay."

5.14 And then 10 days later, he gets a letter from Peter Fraser, and he says, Peter Fraser writes to him and says, "We've discussed it in the cabinet. We've had a day-long parliamentary debate about this question, and we have decided that they may stay." Now, that was up to them. You think about it, they're in danger. And Imperial Japan was not very nice to the people they conquered, but they left them there.

5.15 The one big difference is India. And India was an interesting thing—it's, by the way, in my opinion, one of the most important things in the world these days. It's huge, and it's a representative country. And if you have that, if you have consent of the governed, just remember, it puts a check on whoever's ruling. At Hillsdale College, we have consent of the governed. And what that means is, everybody has to do what the college policy is, which I have something to do with, not everything, but much. And if they don't like it, they can leave. We have competitors all over the place. This is the way we do it. And everybody's told that in advance.

5.16 And it's very sensitive if you change anything significant because it's like breaking a contract. And that means that we don't have a monopoly on force. No private institution does. Governments do. And so, how do you have the consent of the governed? And the answer is, the people have to say yes. And you need a mechanism for that. I'm going to talk about the mechanisms that Britain had and that Churchill favored. But not in India.

5.17 India came into British possession beginning in the late 17th and early 18th centuries, and the way it worked was really amazing. European powers, they're very strong and they're going all over the world, Germany, France, Britain, the main ones. And they have installations along the east coast of India, and they're trading places and stockades. And they buy and sell stuff in India. India has got a lot of cool stuff. That's why Marco Polo wanted to go there. But they mucked around in local politics, too. And that local politics were dominated by these princes. And there were many of them, and they were often in contest with each other.

5.18 And that just opened up a world of opportunity. And there's this man named Clive, later Lord Clive, and he was a bookkeeper, and he'd been a kind of a misfit, younger

son. It's a great story of the empire. There wasn't anything for the younger sons to do. And so he was on the edge of trouble with the law, and he went off to India, and he got to work as a bookkeeper. And one of these wars among the princes, with the Europeans involved, threatens the place where he is, the British settlement where he is. And he went out and joined the fight. He didn't have any military experience at all.

5.19 And about a year and a half later, he had conquered India. He was an excellent battlefield commander, and he was a more excellent diplomatist. And he just puts combinations together. And back home in London, they found out about that after it happened. And he worked for the British East India Company, which was the official ruler of India until into the 19th century. If you look at a really grand British house, one of the magnificent ones, and it was built anytime after 1850, probably the money was made in India.

5.20 It was not a government policy for the longest time. Then they adopted it and they started moving toward forms of self-rule, which operated at the provincial level. In Churchill's lifetime, especially in the early 1930s, but it came up originally—well, it came up an important time in the early 1920s, too—the reform of India rule was a big issue, and Mahatma Gandhi arose, and he was quite a man, and Churchill didn't like him. Churchill opposed vehemently making a promise that India would be returned on any timetable to full self-rule.

5.21 And his argument for that, which he makes all the time, and eloquently, I think, is that India, he says, is not a country, it's a geographic expression. There are many different clans and languages. Martin Gilbert told me one time that the language that the leadership of the Congress Party, Gandhi's party, had in common was English. And Gandhi was educated in Oxford. And the strife between the Muslims and the Hindus was always a powder keg. And Hindus are a big majority; Churchill thought the Muslims were the best fighters.

5.22 And if we leave, he said, there's going to be a blood bath, and it will sink into chaos. And he was right about the first thing. He ultimately was not right about the second thing. They did have a civil war. Probably a million people were killed in it. The result of it was Pakistan was formed as a Muslim nation and India as the Hindu nation. They're both nuclear powers now, facing each other with hostility. It's not like they patched up all their differences. He predicted all that and argued against it and said, "We should just be patient."

5.23 Here's a key point that I think is very important. See, I think Churchill was wrong about something here. I think he thought that there wasn't really an India. And there wasn't an India that included all those people because there isn't today. But there was a very big thing, and it did hang together, only just. And now it's a serious power and a great promise, in my opinion. It's going to be bigger than China pretty soon. And the parliamentary system is holding.

- 5.24 And I think that's great because remember, the key thing is consent of the governed. Because I'm a really sweet guy and you're all very sweet people. Do you want to give us, any one of us, absolute power over any of the rest of us? That would be a good idea? Because what will happen is, you'll soon stop thinking about the interests of that person and you'll start thinking about what you want to do with them included. And so, you have to have a nation to have a mechanism for sharing power, limiting— assembling and limiting power.
- 5.25 Well, he didn't think India could do that, and it almost couldn't, and then it did. And the minute the settlement was made, he became a friend of India. He was a friend of India, he claimed all the time. Churchill fought in India. He began his education there. A great book to read by Churchill is called My Early Life. And one of the chapters is called Education at Bangalore, place in India where he was. And they played polo in India. India was a very luxurious life for a British officer. And they drilled. It was hot.
- 5.26 So in the afternoons, everybody took a long nap, except Churchill. He studied for more than a year. He got his mother and others to send him books. We know what the books were. He read Gibbon and Macaulay. He read Plato and Aristotle, and he read a lot of crazy stuff, too. Winwood Reade, The Martyrdom of Man. The great sacrifice of man is because of belief in God. He said, "I fear that I went through a violent anti-Christian stage, and if I kept it up, I would have become a nuisance."
- 5.27 So he learned there, and he really did learn. It's amazing. What a good—and he didn't have much guidance, too. And so he pieced his education together through a long life and was, ever after that, a spokesman for opportunities to learn for older people because it made his life better, and he thought it makes every life better. So India was important to him.
- 5.28 There are people who write that Churchill was a racist, and he did say as a younger man, especially there aren't very many evidences of this. Especially they come from a man named Leo Amery, who he went to school with and who was a member of Parliament with him. And he quotes Churchill, just three or four things. "I don't like blackamoors" was one of them. And it's interesting, the record of Churchill is so rich, and there's little of that. In fact, it's almost all from Leo Amery.
- 5.29 On the other hand, he writes these beautiful things about the rights of all people, including the Indian people. He demonstrated that he thought that they were capable of self-government by involving them in it on an increasing scale and thought that, ultimately, they had to be able to themselves. Just didn't want to give them a timetable. So that's a controversial thing. The accusation exists that, in the Second World War, the British government controlling grain shipments and everything deliberately starved to death millions of people in India. That's proved not to be true in many places I can show you.

- 5.30 But what did happen was most of the grain came from Indochina, and the Japanese took Indochina. So now the grain doesn't come anymore. And then they had a drought. And so there was a shortage of food, and they needed to ship food in there. But there was a war on. Shipping was scarce as hen's teeth. They did make efforts to ship a lot of food to India, and did ship a lot. But like, Canada, Mackenzie King was the Prime Minister of Canada at the time. Quite an interesting man. Good man, I think. And he offered to basically just give hoards of grain to India.
- 5.31 Churchill wrote him back and said, "Yeah, we got to get it there. There's a lot of grain. How do we get it there?" And a lot of people starved. It's a fact. The idea that that was deliberate by Churchill or anybody in the British government, because the cabinet minutes exist, you can just read what they said about it. What they said is, "This is a crisis. We got to do something. What can we do?" And against that, we've got some millions of soldiers stationed in big battlefield places, and they need supplies and food and weapons, or they'll get killed and we'll lose the war.
- 5.32 Those are hard choices. Churchill made a lot of choices. And unless you feel too much sympathy for him, he was the kind of man who put himself in the place to make choices like that. He was prepared to do that. And so he's blamable or praisable, depending on how he did. And as I said before about that and every other controversial thing about Churchill, and there are plenty, the record is very rich. And if you read it, it's big. Here's a great way to do it.
- 5.33 A very great, the greatest historian that I've ever met, and one of the greatest of the 20th century, is a man named Sir Martin Gilbert, for whom I used to work, who was the official biographer of Winston Churchill. It's kind of a miracle he got appointed to that. But he was thorough and he was careful. Favorite saying is from him. I already mentioned one of them. "We do not use the word perhaps." Another one was, "In 19th- and 20th-century history, there's no room for the word 'perhaps.'" You can look it up. You can find it all out.
- 5.34 He'd say, "You have a good memory, and I have a good memory, and we do not trust our memories." Here am I, trusting my memory all the way through this. But in other words, if a thing becomes interesting to you, and there's a controversy about it, you can look it up. And you'll find out that there's a lot that doesn't appear. Always you'll find this out. There's a lot that doesn't appear on the surface. And sometimes that's just because it's hard to look things up; it takes time. And sometimes that's because, of course, people edit for their own purposes. But you can find out.
- 5.35 And if you like anything about Winston Churchill, and then you don't like some things about Churchill, that's a spur to find out. The question arises, and the question is a pressing question right now in the world, under what circumstances can a country devoted to equal rights and consent of the governed impose its will on another country? And that's a huge moral question, and it comes up all the time. So, reading

Churchill is a way to get into that. And I think he was very wise myself. But I do think he was wrong.

- 5.36 And so, you just think what kind of thing that is. You're asking the question, here's a nation that has never acted as one, except under the British. What will happen when we leave? That's a hard question to answer. It's a hypothetical. And what did happen was disastrous and ultimately great, I think. I mean, the greatness is not established yet, but it's on its way. Read up on Mr. Modi, the Prime Minister. I think he's a galvanizing guy.
- 5.37 Oh, I didn't mention another thing about India, untouchability. The Brahmin class are at the top of the Hindu order, and the lowest class was untouchable. They meant that literally. Martin Gilbert—I've never been to India. I long to go. I'm going to take my girlfriend off to India sometime. It's changed a lot, I understand. But when he was there, in the '60s and a little bit in the '70s, he witnessed an untouchable riot.
- 5.38 And what happened was, the untouchables who were half-starved, shuffled themselves off to somewhere where they're in the way and collapsed on the ground. Then a big refuse truck came up, and cops and refuse workers knocked them in the head with big long truncheons, so they didn't have to touch them. They loaded them in the trucks and hauled them off somewhere and dumped them out.
- 5.39 You see, he was once walking with a man who ran a hospital, and they stepped over a woman dying on the sidewalk. They soon got to the hospital, and he said, "What about that woman?" And he said, "Which woman?" And Martin said, "The woman on the sidewalk back there." And he said, "She is dying." And Martin said, "You have beds here." And the man said, "Oh." So the point is, there's a grace about a caste society. It has its virtues. It wouldn't persist if it didn't, but it has its evils, too. The society devoted to equality has all kinds of dangers associated with it, too.
- 5.40 Anybody else want to go to India? I'd love to go to India. I want to meet Mr. Modi. There's been an untouchable who's been Prime Minister now, but all that is moderated. It's not gone, but it's moderated a great deal. And remember, it's a religious conviction. I think it has to do with reincarnation, but I don't really know. And the point is, the people who have those views think them good, even divinely commanded. And see, it raises a question. What should you do about that?
- 5.41 If you're Britain and you've got power now, it's very important to Churchill that Britain didn't send a force to conquer India just to dominate them. It's very important that it happened the way it happened. And that meant that the British guilt, if it's guilt, is mitigated. And then he thought, "We're good for them." The population has increased. They're not very heavily policed. Most of the policing is done by people of Indian descent. The Indians are accepting of British rule, which, substantially, they were for a long time. And they thrived, and literacy rose, and all kinds of things. And today, they

have a parliamentary form of government, a representative form of government. Britain has something to do with that being there.

- 5.42 It's very unfashionable now, but I've lived a long time, so I've seen all kinds of things happen. I think it was back in the '70s. There were articles by the Prime Minister on subsequent days and the leader of the opposition. This might have been in the '80s. India was for a long time an ally of the Soviet Union, and it's still partial to Russia. They have interests, and they have China to worry about. That was not handy for the Western alliance, but India was there. They founded the non-aligned movement, which was in some places aligned with the Soviet Union. Anyway, they began to come out of that. The collapse of the Soviet Union helped.
- 5.43 And Reagan had a very aggressive and good, I think, foreign policy toward India. And George W. Bush, in particular, did, too. Thought them important, wanted to ally with them. Anyway, the Prime Minister and the leader of the opposition on subsequent days said, "Come to India. Invest and be our friends." It's the point of the columns. "And we have a parliamentary system of government. You can rely on us." Well, that's a blessing. And so far as it goes, right?
- 5.44 Churchill's hope was that the world could be like that. And he didn't think it was a project to make the world like that. It's very tricky about this because Aristotle says, in a person, "you are what you do." You become what you do. If you do it for a long time, that's what you'll be. Countries are like that, too. Alexander the Great went to conquer India. He was extremely determined to do that and didn't want to stop when he got there. His soldiers rebelled, and he couldn't go any farther. And that's because he just wanted to go conquer them, make them civilized.
- 5.45 Britain didn't really do that. Imperial Japan did that in Asia. And Churchill thought that was important. It says something about the origin of the thing and the character of the thing. And that means that we can be a liberal society. And to the extent that we rule anybody, we have to rule them in their interest and toward their ultimate self-rule. In his July Fourth speech that I mentioned last time, in 1918, he said, "By the Declaration of Independence, we lost an Empire, but by learning its lessons, we preserved an Empire."
- 5.46 And so his view was that the British Empire exists in service of the Declaration of Independence. Now, that may be a fraud, and it may not be, but he did say it all his life. And you can read—how do you find out if somebody's sincere? Well, you can only compare what they say to what they do. But I can tell you in private conversation, in cabinet meetings and in private, there are just not instances of Winston Churchill saying, "We are the superior people and we get to rule other people." That's not what he thought. He would say, "We are more civilized than other people."
- 5.47 But that brings me now to one of my favorite things he wrote, which is a very short speech. Mr. Juan Davalos over there is going to take care of you getting a whole bunch

of readings about Churchill. If I'd gotten them to you earlier, then you would have been under a greater onus to read them, but I didn't know what was going to happen. In 1938, Churchill is still the longest-serving Chancellor of the University of Bristol, down on the south coast, and he was very proud of that. He loved that place.

- 5.48** There's early video of him in the 1930s being carried around by a mob of students on their shoulders. He loved to go there. And in 1938, he gave a commencement address. And this is in the summer of 1938, and Hitler is looming. The war started in 1939. And the speech is about that long, and it's called Civilization. And he says, "What does it mean?" Have you thought about that word? What does it mean? It jumps in your mind about paintings and sculptures and poetry and fancy stuff. It does mean that. It comes from the Latin word for citizen. Civic duty, civility, civil.
- 5.49** Churchill says, "What does it mean? It means the rule of civilians. It means the power of despotic chiefs bow to the right of ordinary people." And think what a feat that is to make that happen. Because the strong, why would they obey the weak? And the stronger in the army and the people the army listens to, why, why should they? Well, they have to have a sense of civilization. They have to obey. The strong have to obey the weak. But of course, that's not enough because the weak will speak with many voices. There has to be a way to find out what the most of them think.
- 5.50** And that's why you need elections, and you need forms, and you need them to be stable so they can be trusted. Right now, one of the grim things about America is that we don't trust our elections anymore. It's almost a crime to say it, but it's just the case that if you ask, do a poll, very large numbers of the American people say they don't trust the elections, which is something different than thinking that the election was stolen. I personally don't know that, but they did monkey with it quite a bit. And that's—trust is eroded.
- 5.51** I'll be accused of being responsible for that. What I'm for is clear rules that stay the same for a long time. And then you can trust it, right? But civilization depends on that, the rule of law, because the law is not a person. So you have to obey something that can't really act. And he says, "From civilization grows comfort and culture and knowledge." That's a paraphrase. It's not exactly what he said, but it's close.
- 5.52** And see, that means that if you can live in a place that has the rule of law, things are predictable, and that liberates one to act, to plan, to build. That blessing is all too rare. And this speech in 1938— and see, that's Hitler, right? He sees that. He's working on that all the time now. And that thing is coming and did come. So he's reminding everybody in that speech—it's one of my favorite speeches of his, not as well-known as many—but he's reminding, what are the conditions of living well for everybody? And they're here in the rule of law. So he believed in that.
- 5.53** So now, what does the rule of law require? There's a list of things. It's famous. Churchill would recite this list often, and he was good at it. He could put it in pretty language. I

said before, these two individual little places, he would call them, that represent the greatness of the British nation. And one of them is, one person in a booth, alone, deciding. And the other is the House of Commons, where everything has to be argued in public and where it's reported verbatim.

- 5.54** The Hansard, which is the record of the parliamentary debates, is still verbatim. In the Congressional record in America, they can stick anything in it if they want. They just take a paper to the clerk and say, "Put that in the record," right? The Hansard is what is actually said in the chamber. Interesting fact, Charles Dickens was a Hansard writer for some years. He'd sit and write down what they said in the Parliament. Thank god his novels don't always sound like the politicians.
- 5.55** So that means that people can participate. They can know. I will tell you, the key to running a college is: the only way to keep a secret is don't have one. Tell everybody everything. It's just better. There's a limit. I don't tell them bad stuff about individual people. I tell them, "I can't tell you that; that's bad stuff about an individual person." Half the time, most everybody knows who it is, but you don't use the name. There should be room for young people to be anonymous and do stupid things because they are going to do stupid things. No question about it. Yet more often than I do, and that's saying something.
- 5.56** So, Churchill believed that this chamber in the House of Commons was the living place of British life. And they're elected, they're enormous efforts. Millions of people pick them from all over the country in constituencies, by the way, that are stable for a long time and established. And they represent parts of the country, but they represent the people in those parts. And of course, the people change their minds all the time. And that's why they have to have elections pretty often.
- 5.57** And then Churchill wanted it—it used to be true, in the period of time of my research into Britain, which is mostly the life of Churchill, which is a long time, they used to reprint in several newspapers everything said in Parliament the day before, and people would read it. Churchill thought that was the greatest thing in the world. He thought—because why? Because we come here and argue, and they know these arguments, and they argue, and they form their views, and those are reflected at the next election.
- 5.58** That's a big point with James Madison, that you have to have—one of the reasons you need a big country is it's impossible to rule it by whispering. Things can only advance if you can say them out loud, because you can't reach enough people if you don't do that. And then he loved it. The American people are very conditioned by their Constitution. The British, too, it's more regular than it used to be. But in the British Parliament, in most parliamentary systems, there could be an election at any time. Prime Minister calls one, and he might just call one because he thinks he'll get more seats if he does it right now. It's always risky when you do that.

- 5.59 Here, the elections are timed every two years, every four years, every six years for the Senate. And that means that Americans are accustomed to pay more attention to politics close to elections. And you can watch polling change as people think about it. If you ask them, when a certain—I won't name any candidates, but quite a while ago, whoever he was—he just said he was going to run for President, so he did a whole bunch polling. What are people concerned about? What's the next election going to turn to?
- 5.60 And one of his items was, "Takes too long to get to soccer practice." And the reason is, that's what people were thinking about right now. They don't really have anything to do in the political system except think and argue about the stuff that comes up. But what's on your mind? I got to get the kids to soccer practice. And he actually said that in a speech. I went, "Wow, look at that." We're not to the place yet where the American people expect the President to drive their kids to soccer practice. First of all, you wouldn't trust him to do it.
- 5.61 So this continuing debate, Churchill hated it. He writes about how early in his career, people rated politicians like they rate sports figures. And he liked that. And he was often excoriated. He didn't mind; he'd argue back. He wrote an essay called Cartoons and Cartoonists, and it was a chance for him to reprint a lot of the famous cartoons about him. And for some reason, somebody just drew this once. He was often depicted as a man with a huge head and a little bitty hat on top. And he hardly ever wore hats. But no, he was this guy with this big head and this little hat.
- 5.62 And he says that, when he doesn't see one of those for a while, he misses it, because people are paying attention. They're participating in the rule. He liked elections. I mean, they're exhausting, and you still have got all your work to do, right? So he didn't like that. But when he got up there in it, it was a hoot. And he was shouted down. He was struck with a bullwhip by a suffragette. And of course, he wrote an essay about that. He wrote an essay about everything.
- 5.63 And so, it's a participatory thing. And people are thinking. And then it comes time for them to do something, and they've been thinking. And that's reinforcement of the adage that you should probably think before you act. So he admired that about the British political system very much. The government in Britain, the executive branch and the judicial branch are both inside the Parliament. Isn't that weird?
- 5.64 He argued incessantly—and he was right, I think— that it's actually a system of separation of powers. Because once the government is picked by the majority party, they've got to report to it in every debate. And the Parliament can throw them out any day it wants to, and it does. The great old thing is, the Labour party talks all the time about changing its leader; it seldom does. The Conservative party never talks about it, and it often does. And that means that they've all got to stand up.

- 5.65 And the backbenchers, those are the ones behind the government. Well, no, the backbenchers on the other side of the one, side of the leaders, the opposition, they will generally support their side, but they have to make a speech and they have to answer for it. And that means that they're often critical, too. So, debate. Churchill was a really good debater, really. He loved the House of Commons in particular. They shouted him down a lot. He was provocative. He's extremely interesting. And the House of Commons fills up when an excellent speaker stands up. And it's pretty empty other times.
- 5.66 And so when he would stand up, you just watch people flowing in. And then many of them came to shout at him, and he would get their attention sometimes. Once he said, "I am merely stating my opinion. You will have a chance to state your opinion. This is the process we call debate," stuff like that. Another time, they were roaring at him in the 1920s, and Stanley Baldwin, who was a very unfortunate Prime Minister, but extremely skillful, and he made Churchill Chancellor of the Exchequer.
- 5.67 And so you have the speeches in the Hansard, but you also have the letters that Stanley Baldwin wrote to the King, characterizing them. And Stanley Baldwin was often at odds with Winston Churchill, but he realized he was some kind of genius. And once he says, the Labour Party, the Socialists on the other side, they're just shouting. And Churchill, he'd make his voice big, and he said, "Honorable members opposite may not wish to hear my words. And if not, I do not wish to cast my pearls." And Baldwin reports that they all gathered themselves to scream at him when he calls them swine. And then he says in a quiet voice, "before those who do not want them." And they all collapse in laughter.
- 5.68 Things like that are a lot of fun. And he had a lot of fun. And they were governing out loud, and people were paying attention. And that's open and responsive. And he valued that very much. In Britain, you face the opposition directly. They're right there. And you go in the back and long aisle, benches on either side, the speaker is in front of you, up a little higher. It has the mace on it and it has a dispatch box on it. And it sticks out a ways. And that means that the people on the front rows, nearest the speaker, have a table in front of them. They have a place to put down some notes. Nobody else does.
- 5.69 And so, that's privileged. It's comfy. What Churchill did when he was out of office, because he became senior member of Parliament eventually, is that table ends and the treasury bench is called the nearest the speaker first row. That's the heads of the government. That ends. And then there's a stairway going up into the benches. And the seat just on the other side of the gangway on the front row, Churchill was a very distinguished member, very controversial, but very distinguished. He would always sit in that seat, and people would let him.
- 5.70 One of the rules is, if you go in there, you can go in there. You're not allowed to sit in any seat. Let's just say I happen to know where Churchill sat, and it was a terrible temptation. I won't tell you whether I gave into it or not. But because of his location, he

could stand up and he could move over a couple of steps, and he had the table. And he had notes. He didn't refer to them very much, but he had them. And so that meant that, especially when he was fighting with the Prime Minister of his party, the Prime Minister was actually looking at his butt while he talked. Churchill liked that.

- 5.71** Churchill wanted to reform the system. He wanted to restore having a second chamber, this one on some popular basis, not hereditary. And he saw the advantages of that because everything's got to be debated twice and makes it harder, also more thorough and exhausting. Exhaustive and exhausting. He had a plan for that. I mentioned it. He wanted regional parliaments. He wanted parliament to be dealing with the great national affairs and only them.
- 5.72** That's actually how our Constitution is written. Do you know in Article 1, Section 8, how many things there are that the Congress is allowed to do? There's 17. And half of them are national defense, half of them are national system of commerce, and then a couple of add-ons where the federal government gets to operate on the property that it occupies, because the post office is in some state and all that. And so it's limited. They do everything now.
- 5.73** But if a legislative body is controlling details, it breaks down. They have to delegate it to experts to do it. And so Churchill's solution to that problem was, the main way to delegate is just let people do it themselves. I'm in a big controversy right now because I'm arguing that schools don't need administration in the center. If all of us, just us, if we said, next year we're going to start and run a school, I submit you could do that, figure out how to do that without me. It's not that hard.
- 5.74** First of all, think what they need to know. Reading, writing, arithmetic, history, literature, philosophy, biology, chemistry, physics. They need those things. That means you know the human skills, that's what reading, writing, arithmetic are, and you know, you have knowledge of the main things in the world. That's hard to get. It's not hard to name.
- 5.75** Anyway, I argue that. I think the focus should be on the parents and the teachers, and let them figure it out. If they don't do well, give them a choice. Let them take them to another school. Anyway, that's my plan. It's crazy. It places me in opposition to the most powerful people in the world, but it would be a lot cheaper, and I argue it would be a lot better.

Lecture 6: Churchill on Civilization

At a glance — Churchill on civilization.

- 6.1 At the same—roughly and almost exactly at the same time in his life, Churchill became afraid of massive war when he saw that it was possible. If it's possible, then it's likely to happen. I told you last time, he spent much of his life thinking through how to limit the cost of war, so that you're not destroyed by it. And so that you can reserve the resources of the nation for the well-being of the people as much as possible in their own hands.
- 6.2 Well, now there's this plan, and the property is all going to be commonly owned. And he thinks that that's the death of civilization itself. And he's there. In fact, the Labour party, the socialist party in Britain, elected members of Parliament for the first time in the same year that he was first elected. He calculated very much in his career about keeping them from getting a majority because he said it will be the death of civilization itself.
- 6.3 Why? Because if the government owns the means of living, what independence do you have to exercise control over the government? And he fought against that, and he lost in 1945. Very much of the things he did in domestic policy were calculated to prevent them from coming in. And the social safety net— I mean, first of all, he just thought it was a scandal that people would have hard jobs for a long time. And if they got sick, they'd lose their children. And read Charles Dickens. That's what he's about.
- 6.4 And Churchill was horrified by that. And so he started working. He left the Tories because he was a free trader. And the Tories, it used to be—Britain has changed so much, been changing for a long time—it was the party of the country and the party of the towns. The country was the great landed estates. They love taxes on imports of food because it makes their crop prices higher. That was an old tradition in Britain.
- 6.5 One of the hallmarks, one of the key points in the development of a wider representative system in Britain, was the repeal of what they called the Corn Laws. Corn means edible grain in Britain. They repealed the tariffs on imports of food. Churchill was all over that. He just thought that was the greatest thing in the world. The Conservative party came round to that, and they supported it, too. All that happened beginning in the middle of the 19th century.
- 6.6 Then they started widening the franchise. It wasn't actually universal suffrage in Britain until about 1928. But in steady steps, if women vote, that was a big step. Churchill was for that with caution, I would say. Lincoln was a big women's suffrage man, by the way. I'm for that. He invented the social safety net. And what was it? It was social insurance. There was 244 pence in the pound, and every pound you made, nine pence went into an insurance policy. Three pence came from you, and four pence came from the

employer, which economists will tell you means it all came from you. Two pence, tuppence, came from the government.

- 6.7 That meant that people, if they got sick, they had insurance. If they got hurt at work, they had insurance, and they had death benefits. Churchill believed that that would solidify the country around the Constitution and limit government. And this was passed in 1909-10. And sure enough, the Tories dominated the middle and much of the working-class vote until the end of the Second World War. And that's because people had some safety and they wanted to work, and if they worked, they could do well, pretty well. That was a scheme on his part. He believed in it.
- 6.8 There's a great telling thing. In the '20s, when Stanley Baldwin was Prime Minister, they appointed him Chancellor of the Exchequer, and he was very energetic. This is a time of peace. In fact, it's the only time of peace and prosperity in which Winston Churchill was a senior politician. After that, the '30s and the Great Depression, and he's on the outs with the Conservative party. Then he's Prime Minister during the war. Then after the war, the socialists are in for five years. He's leader of the opposition.
- 6.9 Then he's reelected, and he becomes Prime Minister again, and Britain was broke, and they did put it back together and got it going again. And he did that by scrimping and saving and keeping taxes as low as they could. There was a revival there, but by that time, it wasn't the same country anymore, and he was a very old man. Now, what does that mean? That means this incredible active fellow, who had this unsurpassed duration in politics, ran out of time, which is what happens to everyone's life. I'm going to run out of time sometime.
- 6.10 I was agreeing with Dennis Prager, the radio host. We had dinner last night, and he and I were agreeing, "Yeah, well, wouldn't it be better to die in the saddle?" So he wants to preserve a Britain that's independent. He wants a Britain that is formidable, that can enforce freedom of the seas, that can go anywhere it needs to go and trade with anyone it wants to trade with, without tariffs. He wants all of that. He doesn't want a big army. He regrets nuclear weapons, which he supported, had to. In other words, he wants it safe, and the safety maintained by a method that doesn't detract from its strength or its freedom. He wants that.
- 6.11 He wants the government to be representative, and that means closely representative. That means the debates are attended to. Active citizenship, that's his model. He wants that. He wants people involved. If he's going to talk to a crowd, he wants it to be a big crowd. If he's going to have an argument, he wants it to be a big argument. He gets tired like most people, but just not as much. But he thinks it's healthy when it's like that, and he wants to widen the representative function.
- 6.12 The Congress of the United States makes a small minority of the laws in America now; so also in Britain. And that means the House of Commons is not the center that it used to be. And if it's going to govern the way it governs, where everything is, as we say in

America, everything is a federal case, then you can't do that in a Congress or a Parliament. There's just not enough time. So you have to have experts making rules all the time. And it's very difficult to keep that process accountable.

- 6.13** And so to cut the need for that, Churchill—and he believed in the civil service. They got scrappy with him many times, and he was good at arguing with them. And he invented the phrase that he would use against some important ones, "No longer civil, no longer servants." I confess I've used that expression a couple of times myself. But you need that, and you need them to be impartial. That means you need them not to be a political force. They are in Britain and America a major political force now, especially here. That would guarantee the independence of the British people.
- 6.14** And what is the ultimate object? He's poetic, and so he'll say things like, "The object of the British government is the well-being of the person of the family in its cottage home, its ability to provide for itself and make its own decisions and raise its children." See? That means, if that is the ideal life, everyone can be a king, but you have to preserve people's independence.
- 6.15** In the second premiership, the socialists are in now, and they socialize nine major industries. He had a thought about that. They were elected to do that. They said they were going to do that. They got a big majority. They can't be stopped, and they shouldn't be stopped. They should be argued with. When Churchill came back in with a smaller majority, he only undid one of those. Here is his argument. He made arguments like this a lot.
- 6.16** He says, "A typical parliament lasts five years. In the first two years, they should do the controversial things they have been elected to do. In the next two years, they should do less controversial things. In the last year, they should make their case about the future." That means they socialized the steel industry, the socialists did, in the fifth year. When Churchill was elected, he undid that. He made a very telling speech about it. He quoted the socialist Prime Minister, Clement Attlee, the first socialist Prime Minister with the majority.
- 6.17** He was a colleague of Churchill's in the war. He was Deputy Prime Minister through the Second World War. They liked each other. And that's another thing; they were civil to each other, which means they would just dress each other down in Parliament, but they were friendly, too. And they never impugned each other's honor. Some of the greatest testimonies of what Churchill was like as a colleague are from Clement Attlee.
- 6.18** The foreign secretary is a very colorful guy. What he was was a very left-wing union organizer, when Churchill was Chancellor of the Exchequer. Churchill got to know him and figured out he was a great patriot, Ernest Bevin. He got Ernest Bevin into politics. Ernest Bevin was an anti-communist socialist, and he was the foreign secretary in that 1945 to 1951 administration when the Cold War started. Churchill had great confidence in him, but he thought he was a crazy socialist. They didn't—see, they thought, if they

actually get a majority in a serious argument where everybody knows to do a thing, then they can do it.

- 6.19** Now, it's a little different here because our Constitution works differently. There's also the abiding influence of the Constitution. That means you may not like that, then you can amend the Constitution, but that's, by design, very difficult to do. He sees a world that's flexible. Well, the guy, he helped to invent this social safety net. That thing worked for a long time. It was insurance. In 1925, when he becomes the Chancellor of the Exchequer, there's a deputation that comes to see him, of industrialists, they call them, big business guys. A couple of them are members of the House of Lords, and they're smart.
- 6.20** One of them I know a fair amount about, and he was pretty good. He said, "Don't these social safety net things erode personal responsibility? Because people should really take care of themselves and their families." Churchill said, "They do in a way, but look what you get for it." In other words, even though we're subsidizing this a little bit, they don't remember that. That's investing, and that reinforces their independence. It doesn't erode it. And that seems to me, and that's because, in principle, by the way, on pure libertarian principles, you wouldn't do that.
- 6.21** Sure enough, you're right. If somebody gets sick, the family should help them. The community should help them. Everybody should help them, right? In Hillsdale, we have a graduate student who's got a two-year-old kid with cancer, and the treatment is extremely expensive. And I'm rather glad about Obamacare. But the family expenses, a bunch of us were giving money to them. It's not a lot of money, but it's enough. And we took trouble to find out how much was enough. Well, that's the right way to do it. But what if there was \$700,000 to pay? Well, I'll tell you, I would try to raise it, but might not be easy.
- 6.22** You don't want—because that's a weapon, too. In other words, your health care, if you buy it, they're all working for you. If somebody else buys it, who are they working for? That's what's my opinion. One of the things that's wrong with education, you're owed it. And that means, if you go, it's supposed to be free, and if you don't learn, it's somebody else's fault. But look at all of you. You're here. Travelled to get here, hard to get here. You could be doing anything right now. In other words, you want to do this. And that's what it takes to make it work, to learn, because learning is a special thing. Even curing physical ailments requires a lot of cooperation from the patient. But learning, that's just going on in here and here.
- 6.23** You had mentioned that Churchill was an imperialist and ruling some without their consent. It's a question that I've been thinking about for a while, and it goes along with, as well, you've mentioned Churchill going through an anti-Christian stage, but instead, he said he'd be more nuanced if he'd kept it up. I feel like there's a lot of people now with the conversation of anti-religious organization, and the US government is too far overreaching their rule and their law. I would just be interested on what was Churchill's

thoughts on that more. So is it an imperialist view, or what resources would we go to learn more on his opinions on?

- 6.24** Oh, well, there's just everything. First of all, Churchill was a huge defender of religious freedom and a proponent of Christianity as a positive force in the land. He said once he was a flying buttress. You know what that is? If you look at a Gothic church, there's big, tall walls, but on the outside, there are some supports that go up like this and over like this and hold it up from the outside. He's a flying buttress. He supports the church from the outside.
- 6.25** He never says he's not a Christian. He speaks many, many good words for Christianity and believes that it is very positive. "The last word in ethics is the Sermon on the Mount." He says that. Now, without their consent—oh, and this anti-Christian phase, he's talking about when he was a boy. I've never had the pleasure of being a girl, but I know that boys are stupid, and I surely was, and Churchill was in some important ways. But you should read *My Early Life* because it's very charming about that in particular. It's also about boys and what they're like.
- 6.26** About without consent. That's only provisional. That can only be justified by the singular circumstances of the British Empire. You've got to remember, I mean, lord, I read something this morning from the American Medical Association. "We have to count up all the indigenous peoples wherever we live, and we have to apologize to them for taking their land." In other words, we carry a weight of responsibility about which we can do nothing. I don't, it doesn't seem right to me.
- 6.27** Now, what Churchill thought was, "There's nothing wrong with going somewhere to trade." And there were some wrongs in there because somebody who gets on a sailboat and goes to India and builds a stockade and starts a trading post, that's likely to be a pretty tough person. And then there'll be missionaries there, too. Is it right to try to convert them? If you don't do it by force, of course, it's right. Churchill loved about Christianity that it means limited government because everybody's the same before God, and God does not anoint rulers. And yet you're required on pain of salvation to follow Jesus.
- 6.28** But that does mean, nobody can make you. And that means, if the government tries, that's despotism. So he thought that was a civically healthy religion, an ethically healthy religion. He didn't think Hinduism was. But as amended, it could be. It depends on respect for the elders, for the belief in some chain of life where the good you do here leads to a better life the next time. I think it's what it's about; I don't really know.
- 6.29** For anything, except certain modern things, in my opinion, anything that commands the loyalty of millions and millions of people for generations and generations, there's got to be something good in it, and you should look for that. I think these modern scientific tyrannies are the one thing I know of that fail that test. And the proof that

they fail it is they proceed by force from the first moment till their death. And that's the only way they can make it work. Yeah.

- 6.30** This is a follow-up question to that one, but you mentioned that he emphasized the importance of separation of powers in government. In such an Anglican environment, what were his thoughts on the separation of church and state and the lack of that in Britain?
- 6.31** Yeah, that's good. Well, that problem was solved in Britain, because in Britain, in the great conflicts that shaped the British Constitution, the church is often a big player, political player. And that's one reason why archbishops get killed and kings get beheaded. Yeah. And so that was over, right? They're not ruling anymore. And the House of Lords, which includes all those bishops, Churchill's idea was that— he accepted for a long time, and I would accept today, except they're all idiots, I think, that they could delay a law passed through the House of Commons or make them vote again or something. But they can't really do that now.
- 6.32** I once had an argument. I don't know. I might have a fit of caution here. I don't know. Let's say that I had an argument a long time ago with a distinguished socialist from Britain, and he said, "There is no British Constitution." I said, and you know, he's, it's a bunch of Americans. "There's no British Constitution." Everybody, "OK." I said, "Is that right?" And he said, "Well, yeah, there's no." I said, and I thought it could become a little skirmish. And I didn't want to have a skirmish with the man in those circumstances, whatever they were. And I said, "How does the House of Lord work after these recent amendments? Can they still delay the implementation of an act of the House of Commons?" He said, "Yes," he said, "especially if it's a constitutional issue." I said, "A what?" And that was bad, worse than I intended. Yeah.
- 6.33** You had said earlier that there are people who will say that Churchill was racist. I guess I'm curious to know whether or not you're also one of those people. Do you believe that?
- 6.34** I do not. I wouldn't like him if I did. I think he—Churchill was, you got to remember, he grew up in the 19th century. Well, he did, almost to growth. But he said these beautiful things and acted on them for a long long time that you're a human being. Everybody in this crowd is a human being. If we weren't, we couldn't talk to each other. That means we face a problem that no other being on Earth faces, and that is, we're mortal beings, and we're aware of our death and mortality, and we make choices about how to register our lives for the good.
- 6.35** That's the challenge we all face, right? That's what we have to do. And good times and bad times, both present challenges like that. And that means, what does color have to do with it? I'm so frustrated these days because you're meant to pretend that race is dispositive. But we have a granddaughter living in town right now and a grandson, but

he's not interesting yet. She's the talkingest little thing you ever saw. She's actually using some real live words now. She makes up others.

- 6.36** The point is, where does that come from? How does she do that? She does it. You don't teach her to do it. She wants to do it. Aristotle says in Book 3, Chapter 4, of the *De Anima*, On the Soul, he says that this is plastic-informed. It's formed into a bottle. And since he thinks that being is a very active thing, he thinks that the form is something holding it together, is what it is. You could cut it up, you could burn it, you could do a lot of things to it. But while it's here, it's informed, and that's an activity in it. It's keeping it what it is.
- 6.37** Now, how do we see that? The answer is, he says, because it'd be laborious to describe exactly what it is about this that makes it a bottle. And yet we instantly see it. The granddaughter sees it right now. Bingo. She sees it. Nobody has to tell her. She sees it. How is it that we are able to do this? Our soul, by the way, is all of us. It's not anywhere. How are we able to do it? And he describes what it has to be like for us to do that.
- 6.38** And he says that the active intellect, that's the part that goes out and looks—of course, it can't be going anywhere because it has to be nothing before it thinks. Because anything it was would be in the way. And then that, one of my teachers loved to say, imagine a little workman coming out from here and going to work in here and building one of these things. You've got the picture perfectly if you can just eliminate the workman. So, you see that's—everything, everything we do is contingent on our being able to do that.
- 6.39** And if the color of our skin changes our ability to do that, then there's no resolution for us, in my opinion. How would you know that it's wrong to treat X and Y differently unless you know what kind of thing X and Y are? It's hard to even talk about these these days because we can't see that so well anymore. And it's such a big thing to learn, to see things like that, because you can learn better if you see that.
- 6.40** To be a scholar, it means you have to doubt yourself a lot. You have to check all the time. Being a scholar often involves a sense of pride or shame in alternation. "Yeah, that was right. That's not right." And that means you have to subject yourself to that. And that means that just because you say so is not the rule. My opinion about being a teacher is never pretend that it is. Because first of all, it won't work. You guys are people. You're going to figure it out for yourself. The equality of the human being is in that operation.
- 6.41** "Animals then use their"—I've memorized this passage. "Animals then use their voices to indicate pleasure and pain. But we use ours to distinguish the just from the unjust." And the speaking animal is the political and rational animal. And it's the speaking, right? A great teacher of mine named Harry Jaffa, we studied Aristotle with him, and Lincoln, two favorite subjects, and other things, too. In one blessed class, there was a

bunch of animal rights activists in the class, undergraduate students, and they were angry and full of resentment and all that. He just had a ball with them.

- 6.42 One class, the great subject was dolphins getting caught in fishing nets. And that was cruel. It had to be stopped. Jaffa said to this girl—I can remember the scene—he said, "Do the dolphins complain of this?" And she said, "Well, they scream." He said, "Do they?" He said, "Does any of them ever say, 'Don't put this net on me'?" Because that's different than just saying, "I don't like this." Do not, this net. What's a net? How do you know what it is? How can you say it?
- 6.43 And he said, "Because if one of them does, you're going to have to let them vote." They're rational animals now. And that means that—isn't that a weird idea that the form of the dolphin could be human if it could talk? It's one reason why anthropomorphized animals are a favorite dramatic theme. They do seem—C.S. Lewis argues that the beings have connections among them. And one of his proofs for that is, we look like animals and animals look like us. And, of course, he's got in Narnia tale, sorry, in the Space Trilogy, which I think is very great, there's lots of talking animals.
- 6.44 And that's good, you see, because if you depict that, then it helps you isolate what it is that's remarkable about us, about what we can do. Out of the silent planet, there's a walrus-looking thing, and he talks. And then he says, in this passage, he mentioned Churchill a few times in his life. He admired Churchill very much. He's not terribly open about it because he wasn't about politics. He says, "Haven't you noticed that that great statesman, Winston Churchill, looks like a frog?" And I thought, "I have never noticed that."
- 6.45 But then, not long after, I ran across a famous picture of him. There's a speech he gave about India when he was fighting the government about India in a theater in Cannon Street. It's called the Cannon Street Speech. And the photograph is taken. He's looking at his notes. He's got his glasses down here like this. And the photograph is taken from below, up on, he's on a dais, and he's just getting ready to give his talk. And I said, "Wow, he looks exactly like a frog."
- 6.46 You see, so that's—and what that means is, the physical confirmation of a rational being is not dispositive. And that doesn't mean the physical things can't be terribly important, because we're not only rational beings. Isn't it a wonderful twist of fate or providence that our babies are hard to raise? They take a long time. My wife is the best person I know, and she has cared for everything under her charge, which is everything, for the 43 years I've known her, more than that, actually. And now she's got these grandkids.
- 6.47 And this daughter that she cared for, stayed up with in the night and had allergies and all kinds of interruptions, she was always a good sleeper. That ended when we had our first child. I've never been a good teacher, a sleeper, so it didn't make a big deal to me. Well, now that woman is bringing her kid over all the time. If we were not human, none

of us would know who each other is. What does it take to produce that? It takes time and energy and sustenance. That's what the family provides. I'm not very important in our family, but Penny needs me to do her work. So I'm here to help her. That's really what I do. I have this other job, but it's a sideline.

- 6.48** In other words, the physical things matter to us very much, but they don't matter in that way. And so, you have to figure out of what compound is the human—from what compound does the human being become an integrity? And the answer is matter and form. And don't mistake the one for the other. It's so hard today not to hurt people's feelings. I pray, pray, touch wood, that it continues, but Hillsdale College is a very relaxed place. You can say about whatever you want to. I can say about whatever I want to.
- 6.49** And people think I'm ridiculous. They think I'm powerful and they think I'm pretty good, but they also think, he's funny, isn't he? And that gives us room to learn, to explore, to experiment. Everything is not a diplomatic address, and it can't be. Kids repeat it now because I'm old now, and that means I have students who are grown people that have become important. Some of them are very important. And so they call me up and tell me what to do. But they repeat things that are favorite things of mine to say.
- 6.50** And so then I ask a question in class. Honor is going on in class all the time. You've got to get rid of that, in my opinion. And so I'll say sometimes, "Wait, is that stupid?" And everybody says, "Yeah." And then I do that to myself, too. Anyway, that's the point. The point is, here's the great—what is the best kind of human association? It isn't justice. Aristotle never calls justice beautiful. And the reason is, there is a kind of justice, that is to say, where everybody gets assigned their due. That's very satisfying.
- 6.51** But most of what justice is about is fixing stuff that went wrong. What's my part? What's your part? Did I get enough? Did you get too much? That's not pretty. So, justice is the first virtue that gets an entire book devoted to it, Book 5 of the Ethics. But then he immediately turns to the intellectual virtues. Books 7, 8, and some of 9 are about the highest human association, and that's friendship. He says that friendship is of three kinds. It's utility. That's when you are an advantage to each other. I like to say, vendors to the college give me Christmas presents, mostly things I can't eat. So I have these 1800 starving mouths to feed, so it's easy to get rid of it.
- 6.52** Then there's pleasure. You delight in somebody. Aristotle says the young are especially given to that because their bodies are in great shape and getting better every day. And then the highest kind, though, is that when you come to love something, the same thing, and high. And that is sublime and it's enduring. And then he says in a friendship like that, it's never the question, "Who got what?" It's the question, "What can I do for you?" See, it's like Christianity.
- 6.53** He says that the highest human experience, he says, there are many beautiful human experiences. Many of them operate on the moral level. You see it in drama all the time.

Somebody saves somebody and sacrifices his or her life doing it. And there's a moment at the end where they feel a great satisfaction. See, that's beautiful. And to do a thing like that is a beautiful thing. And everybody wants to do things like that. It makes you want to cry when you see things like that.

6.54 But the ultimate beauty, he says, the experience of beauty we have, is that it's a kind of beholding that is not thinking about it; it's grasping it, it's holding it, it's seeing it. Often, that's an argument that comes together. Do you ever cry when you study? Yeah, if you don't, you should study harder, because it'll make you cry. And why? You'll just see something.

6.55 I remember one time, Penny and I have been married a long time, and I've been studying Abraham Lincoln and Winston Churchill all that time, and Aristotle and all that stuff. And one time she came in my study a few years ago, and I was sitting there with a book in my hand, and I was crying. And she said, "What's wrong?" I said, "Oh, I'm sorry. I'm reading Lincoln." She said, "What about?" I said, "Well, my friend Lew Lehrman wrote a book about Lincoln's Peoria speech." I went and said I'd read the speech, which I had not read in many years.

6.56 And it's a tremendous intellectual achievement. Not many people could put that together. As a term paper, it'd be hard to write that. And it's a beautiful import and effect. You just see the spectral of it, and all of a sudden it's just too much. Well, that's — friendship around that, that's the best kind, and that's what you're supposed to do, especially in a college. That's what you're supposed to do. Because then you can think, right? And you can make each other better.

6.57 I mean, in 10 days, if I'm not arrested between now and then, I'm going to talk to the freshmen about the honor code. And I'm going to say something I typically say, which is, "I want you to look around you and notice the people near. You might fear that I'm going to say that one of you is going to be gone. I'm not. You are seeing right now a friend for life. You must treat everyone here as if they're potentially that." See, then you can have a learning community.

6.58 And the President can go around and say dumb things, and people don't shoot him. So that's—and what Winston Churchill said about civilization, he didn't lose sight of the fact that it's a simple thing, and we all need it. And to the extent we don't have it, our lives are compromised. Coolidge said, "Great statesmen are the ambassadors of providence sent to reveal to us our unknown selves." Churchill was like that. He could explain, he could see. And of course, he's very controversial. And that's because everything is, and he's an important thing.

6.59 He destroyed Adolf Hitler. No mistake, I think he was a very kindly man, a very generous, well-meaning man. He was also a very lethal man. And that meant, in 1940, when everybody wanted to quit and make peace with him, Churchill didn't just think,

"We can't do that." He thought, "We're going to kill him." And they did. Well, thank you. Great kids.